



National Comprehensive
Cancer Network®

2026

NCCN Guidelines for Patients®

Cancer care recommendations from leading experts at the
National Comprehensive Cancer Network® (NCCN®)

Invasive Breast Cancer



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NCCN Guidelines for Patients®

The essential guide for people facing cancer.

Based on care recommendations from leading cancer experts.

Explains high-quality cancer care provided at
state-of-the-art cancer centers.

Reviewed and revised every year.

Did you know that top cancer centers across the United States work together to improve cancer care? This alliance of leading cancer centers is called the National Comprehensive Cancer Network® (NCCN®).

Because cancer care is always evolving, NCCN develops and frequently updates evidence-based cancer care recommendations used by health care providers worldwide. These recommendations are known as the NCCN Clinical Practice Guidelines in Oncology (NCCN Guidelines®).

The NCCN Guidelines for Patients plainly explain these expert recommendations, so you can talk with your care team about the best care for you.

**These NCCN Guidelines for Patients are based on the
NCCN Guidelines® for Breast Cancer, Version 2.2026 — February 27, 2026.**

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About invasive breast cancer

- 5 What is invasive breast cancer?
- 6 What are the parts of the breast?
- 7 How is invasive breast cancer treated?
- 7 How can I get the best care?

1 About invasive breast cancer

In invasive breast cancer, cancerous cells that arise from the lining of structures in the breast spread into, or invade, the surrounding breast tissue and/or nearby lymph nodes. This guide explains what you need to know about invasive breast cancer treatment.

What is invasive breast cancer?

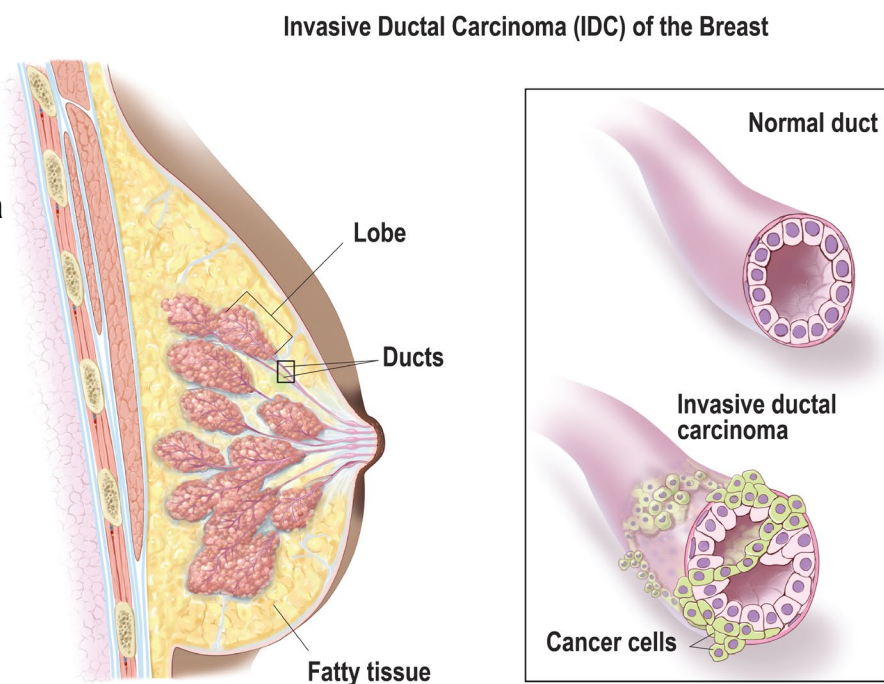
Breast cancer starts in the cells of the breast. Over time, these cells can form a mass, or a tumor. In invasive breast cancer, cancer has spread through the milk ducts or milk glands (lobules) into the surrounding breast tissue.

Breast cancer cells can then spread through lymph or blood to lymph nodes and/or other parts of the body.

Almost all invasive breast cancers are carcinomas—cancers that start in the cells that line the inner or outer surfaces of the body. There are different types of breast carcinoma, most of which arise in cells that make up the lining (epithelial cells) in the terminal duct lobular units (TDLUs) of the breast. A TDLU consists of a lobule connected to the end of a milk duct. The most common types of invasive breast cancer are ductal carcinoma and lobular carcinoma.

Invasive ductal carcinoma

Most breast cancers are invasive ductal carcinomas. This means that cancer started in the cells that line the milk ducts and has spread into surrounding tissue.



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What are the parts of the breast?

Learning about the parts of the breast can help you understand where breast cancer might be found and how treatment, such as surgery, might affect areas of the breast.

The breast is made of milk ducts, fat, nerves, lymph and blood vessels, ligaments, and other connective tissue. Behind the breast is the pectoral (chest) muscle and rib bones. Muscles and ligaments help hold the breast in place.

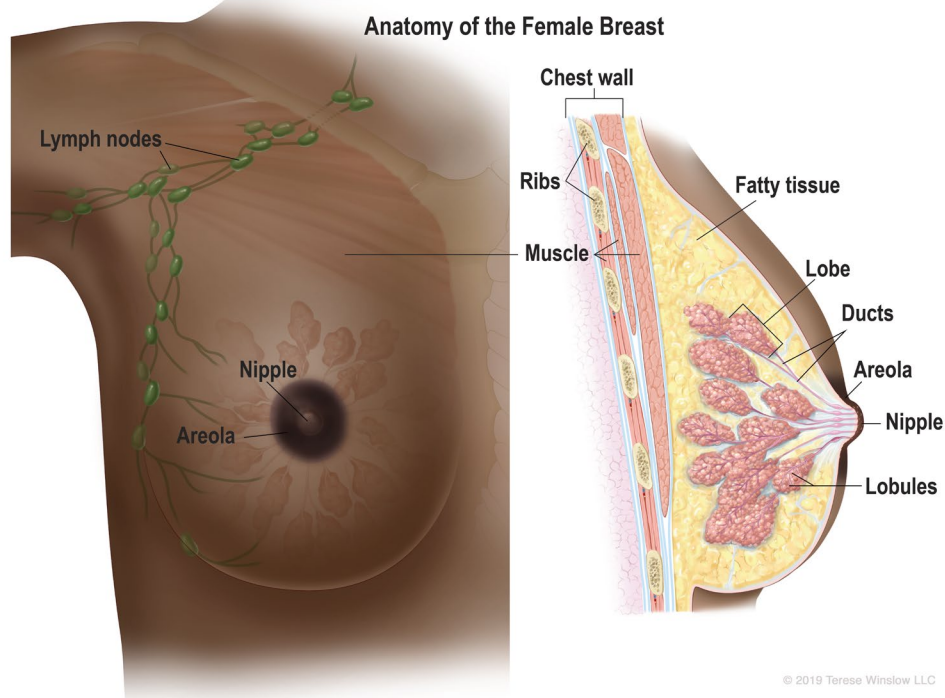
Breast tissue contains glands that can make milk. These milk glands are called lobules. Lobules look like tiny clusters of grapes. Small tubes called ducts connect the lobules to the nipple.

The ring of darker breast skin is called the areola. The raised tip within the areola is called the nipple. The nipple-areola complex is a term that refers to both parts.

Lymph is a clear fluid that gives your cells water and food. It also helps to fight germs. Lymph drains from breast tissue into lymph vessels and travels to lymph nodes near your armpit. Nodes near the armpit are called axillary lymph nodes. Cancer cells can travel through blood and lymph to lymph nodes and other parts of the body.

The breast

The breast is made up of milk ducts, fat, nerves, blood and lymph vessels, ligaments, and other connective tissue.



How is invasive breast cancer treated?

Invasive breast cancer is treated with various combinations of surgery, drug therapy, and radiation therapy. Some people benefit from drug treatment before surgery. Treatment planning is based on the clinical (before surgery) cancer stage, tumor hormone receptor and HER2 status, your overall health, and shared decision-making between you and your care team.

Like other breast cancers, invasive breast cancer can develop in people assigned male at birth. Although there are some differences between breast cancers in people assigned male at birth and those assigned female, treatment is very similar for all genders.

How can I get the best care?

Advocate for yourself. You have an important role to play in your care. Many people feel more satisfied when they actively take part in planning their cancer care.

The NCCN Guidelines for Patients will help you play a larger role in your care. Discuss the recommendations in this guide with your care team. Ask questions about your options and share your goals and concerns.

Don't know what to ask? You're not alone. That's why we include suggested questions to ask at the end of chapters.

Keep reading to find the best care for you.

How this guide can help you

Making decisions about cancer care is stressful. There's a lot to learn, and you don't know what the future holds.

Use this guide to get the information and support you need.

Patients, doctors, and other health care professionals trust the NCCN Guidelines for Patients. This guide uses clear, everyday language to explain current cancer care recommendations made by respected experts in the field. Their recommendations are based on the latest research and practices at leading cancer centers.

Your health is unique to you, so your cancer care should be, too. As you read this guide, you'll learn which treatments are likely to provide the best results for you. And you'll be better prepared to talk with your care team.

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Testing for invasive breast cancer

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2 Testing for invasive breast cancer

Not all breast cancers are the same. Treatment planning starts with testing. Your care team will want to gather information about the cancer you have. This chapter presents an overview of the tests you might receive and what to expect.

Guide 1 Possible tests

Medical history and physical exam

Diagnostic mammogram. Other imaging tests as needed

Biopsy with pathology review

Tumor estrogen receptor (ER) and progesterone receptor (PR) status

Tumor HER2 status

Genetic counseling and testing if at risk for hereditary breast cancer or have triple-negative breast cancer (TNBC)

Discuss fertility and sexual health concerns

Pregnancy test

Distress screening

Lymphedema baseline screening (done after surgery if needed)

Breast cancer treatment is becoming more individualized, and it's important to get the right testing. This takes time but is very helpful in making sure you get the best treatment for your type of breast cancer. Results from a tumor biopsy and imaging studies are used to determine what treatments are best for your type of breast cancer. Tests you might receive are listed in **Guide 1**.

General health tests

Medical history

A medical history is a record of all health issues and treatments you've had in your life. It asks about past surgeries and current health conditions. Bring a list of old and new medicines and any over-the-counter medicines, herbals, or supplements you take. Some supplements interact with and affect medicines your care team may prescribe. Since there's often a lack of published information about how certain supplements interact with standard medicines, your care team may recommend that many of them be discontinued during treatment.

- Some cancers are fed by hormones, such as estrogen. Therefore, it's important to let your medical team know if you're taking any hormones by mouth, through injections, or by placement of a hormone pellet. With a breast cancer diagnosis, hormones such as these will need to be discontinued.

Make sure you tell your care team about any symptoms you have.

Family history

Some cancers and other diseases can run in families. Your care team will ask about the health history of family members who are blood relatives. This information is called family history. Ask members on both sides of your family about their health issues, like heart disease, cancer, and diabetes, and at what age they were diagnosed. It's important to know their specific type of cancer, where the cancer started, if it's in multiple locations, and if they had genetic testing.

Physical exam

During a physical exam, your health care provider may:

- Check your temperature, blood pressure, pulse, and breathing rate
- Check your height and weight
- Listen to your lungs and heart
- Look in your eyes, ears, nose, and throat
- Feel and apply pressure to parts of your body to see if organs are a normal size, are soft or hard, or cause pain when touched
- Examine your breasts to look for lumps, nipple discharge or bleeding, or skin changes
- Feel for enlarged lymph nodes in your neck, armpit, and groin

Clinical breast exam

A clinical breast exam is a physical exam of the bare breast performed by a health care provider to check for lumps or other changes. It's done while you're seated and/or lying down. Your provider should take time to palpate (feel) the entire breast, including the armpit. You can ask a nurse or assistant to be in the room during the exam.

Distress screening

Dealing with a cancer diagnosis can be stressful and may cause further distress. Distress is an unpleasant experience of a mental, physical, social, or spiritual nature. It can affect how you feel, think, and act. Distress might include feelings of sadness, fear, helplessness, worry, anger, and guilt. You may also have depression, anxiety, and sleep issues. Your treatment team will screen your level of distress. This is part of your cancer care.

Lymphedema baseline screening

Lymphedema is a condition in which lymph fluid builds up in tissues and causes swelling. A lymphedema baseline screening measures the fluid levels in your body. It's done in some people to look for small changes in the body after surgery.

Performance status

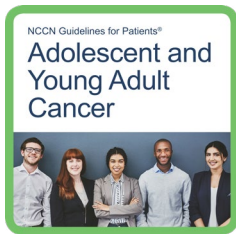
Performance status is a rating of a person's general level of fitness and ability to perform daily tasks. It includes whether you can walk, work, and take care of yourself. It's 1 factor taken into consideration when choosing a treatment plan.

Fertility (all genders)

Treatment with systemic therapy can affect your fertility, or the ability to have children. If you think you want children in the future, ask your care team how cancer treatment might affect your fertility.

Fertility preservation is all about keeping your options open, whether you know you want to have children later in life or aren't sure. Fertility and reproductive specialists can help you sort through what may be best for your situation.

More information on fertility preservation can be found in *NCCN Guidelines for Patients: Adolescent and Young Adult Cancer* [NCCN.org/patientguidelines](https://www.nccn.org/patientguidelines) and on the [NCCN Patient Guides for Cancer](#) app.



Preventing pregnancy during treatment

Preventing pregnancy during treatment is important. Cancer treatment can affect the ovaries, damage sperm, and hurt a developing baby. Therefore, becoming pregnant or having one's partner become pregnant during treatment should be avoided. If you're pregnant or breastfeeding at the time of your cancer diagnosis, treatments may need to be adjusted.



The NCCN Guidelines for Patients are seen as a trusted source by researchers, clinicians, and advocates. They set the standard for appropriate and effective breast cancer treatment, making them a good first step for newly diagnosed patients”

Blood tests

Blood tests check for signs of disease and how well organs are working. They require a sample of your blood, which is removed through a needle placed into a vein in your arm. Some blood tests you might have are described next.

Alkaline phosphatase level

Alkaline phosphatase (ALP) is an enzyme found in the blood. High levels of ALP can be a sign cancer has spread to the bone or liver. A bone scan might be done if you have high levels of ALP.

Complete blood count

A complete blood count measures the levels of red blood cells, white blood cells, and platelets in your blood. Red blood cells carry oxygen throughout your body, white blood cells fight infection, and platelets control bleeding.

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Comprehensive metabolic panel

A comprehensive metabolic panel measures substances in your blood. It provides important information about how well your kidneys and liver are working, among other things.

Liver function tests

Liver function tests look at the health of your liver by measuring chemicals made or processed by the liver. Levels that are too high or low signal that the liver is not working well or that cancer has spread to the liver.

Pregnancy test

People who can become pregnant will be given a pregnancy test before treatment begins.

Imaging tests

Imaging tests take pictures of the inside of your body. These tests show where the cancer is located and the amount of the breast involved. A radiologist, a medical expert in interpreting imaging tests, will interpret the test and send a report to your care team.

Possible imaging tests are described on the following pages. They're listed in alphabetical order and not in order of importance. You won't have all of these tests, and some tests are only done if you have specific symptoms.

Bone scan

A bone scan uses a radiotracer to highlight areas of bone damage or loss. A radiotracer is a substance that releases small amounts of radiation. Before the pictures are taken, the tracer is injected into your vein. It can take a few hours for the tracer to enter your bones.

A special camera will take pictures of the tracer in your bones. Areas of bone damage take up more radiotracer than healthy bone and show up as bright spots on the pictures. Bone damage can be caused by cancer, cancer treatment, previous injuries, or other health issues.

Bone x-ray

An x-ray uses low-dose radiation to take 1 picture at a time. A tumor changes the way radiation is absorbed and shows up on the x-ray. X-rays are also good at showing bone issues. Your care team may order x-rays if your bones hurt or were abnormal on a bone scan.

Contrast material

Contrast material is a substance used to improve the quality of imaging tests, such as CT and MRI scans. It's used to make the pictures clearer. Not all imaging tests require contrast, but many do.

Contrast might be taken by mouth (oral) or given through a vein (intravenously, or IV). The types of contrast vary and are different for CT and MRI.

Tell your care team if you've had allergic reactions to contrast in the past. This is important. You might be given medicines to avoid the effects of those allergies. Contrast

might not be used if you have a serious allergy or if your kidneys aren't working well.

CT scan

A CT, or CAT, scan uses x-rays and computer technology to take pictures of the inside of the body. It takes many x-rays of the same body part from different angles. All of the images are combined to make 1 detailed picture. IV contrast is often used.

Diagnostic mammogram

A mammogram is a picture of the inside of your breast. The pictures are made using x-rays. A computer combines the x-rays to make detailed pictures. A bilateral mammogram includes pictures of both breasts. Mammogram results are used to plan treatment.

Diagnostic mammograms look at specific areas of your breasts, which may not be clearly seen on screening mammograms. Diagnostic mammograms include extra compression in certain areas of the breast, more magnification views, or rolling the breast to image additional areas. Other tests may include a breast MRI or ultrasound.

What's the difference between a screening and diagnostic mammogram?

A mammogram is a picture of the inside of your breast made using x-rays. During a mammogram, the breast is pressed between 2 plates while you stand in different positions. Multiple x-rays are taken. A computer combines the x-rays to make detailed pictures.

Screening mammogram

- Done on a regular basis when there are no signs or symptoms of breast cancer. Results take a few days.

Diagnostic mammogram

- Used for people with symptoms, such as a lump, pain, skin thickening or nipple discharge, or those whose breasts have changed shape or size.
- An ultrasound is often used with a diagnostic mammogram.
- Also used to take a closer look at an abnormal area found in a screening mammogram.
- A radiologist will evaluate the diagnostic mammogram while you wait so if additional testing is needed, it can be done right away.

Both types of mammograms use low-dose x-rays to examine the breast.

2 Testing for invasive breast cancer

MRI scan

An MRI scan uses radio waves and powerful magnets to take pictures of the inside of the body. MRI doesn't use radiation. Because of the strong magnets used in the MRI machine, tell the technologist if you have any metal or a pacemaker in your body. Contrast is often used.

MRI scans take longer than CT scans. A closed MRI has a capsule-like design where the magnet surrounds you. The space is small and enclosed. An open MRI has a magnetic top and bottom, which allows for an opening on each end. Closed MRIs are more common than open MRIs, so if you have claustrophobia (a fear of enclosed spaces), be sure to tell your care team.

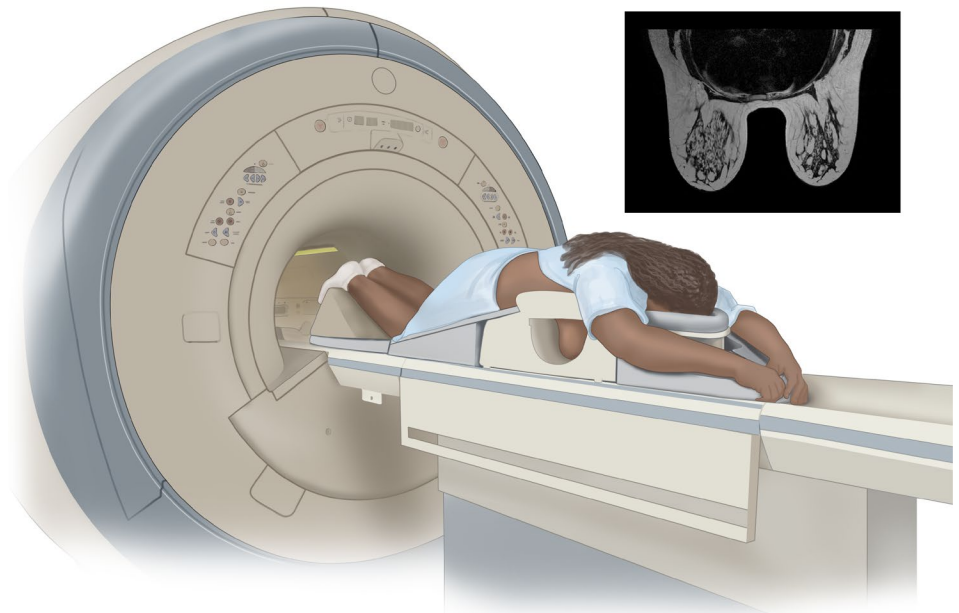
- **A breast MRI** might be used in addition to a mammogram. You will be positioned face down in the machine with your arms above your head. Sometimes, a breast MRI is used to guide a biopsy.
- **A spine or brain MRI** can be used to detect breast cancer that has spread (metastasized) to the spine or brain.

PET scan

A PET scan uses a radioactive substance called a tracer. A tracer is injected into a vein to see where cancer cells are in the body and how much sugar they're taking up. This gives an idea about how fast the cancer cells are growing. Cancer cells show up as bright spots on PET scans. However, not all tumors appear on a PET scan. Also, not all bright spots found on the PET scan are cancer. It's normal for the brain, heart, kidneys, and bladder to be bright on PET. Inflammation or infection can also show up as a bright spot.

Breast MRI

If needed, a breast MRI will be done in addition to a mammogram. In a breast MRI, you're positioned face down with your arms overhead.



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Testing takes time. It might take weeks before all test results come in.

When a PET scan is combined with CT, it's called a PET/CT scan. Types include:

- **FDG-PET/CT** uses a radiotracer called fluorodeoxyglucose (FDG). This scan is most helpful when other imaging results are unclear.
- **Sodium fluoride PET/CT** uses a radiotracer made of sodium fluoride.
- **FES-PET/CT** uses FES, which is a radioactive form of estrogen. An FES-PET/CT might be used when cancer is estrogen receptor-positive (ER+).

Ultrasound

An ultrasound uses high-energy sound waves to form pictures of the inside of the body. This is similar to the sonogram used for pregnancy. Gel will be applied to your bare breast and a wand-like probe (transducer) will be held and moved around your bare breast and near your armpit. Ultrasound doesn't use x-rays, so it can be repeated as needed. Ultrasound is good at showing small areas of cancer near the skin. Frequently, a breast ultrasound is used to guide a biopsy.

Biopsy

A biopsy removes a tissue sample from your body for testing. A pathologist will examine the biopsy for cancer and write a report called a pathology report. Ask questions about your biopsy results and what it means for your treatment.

There are different types of biopsies. Some biopsies are guided using imaging, such as ultrasound or MRI. The main tumor is biopsied first. Other tumors or areas may also be biopsied. You may have tissue removed from the breast, lymph nodes, or both.

Types of biopsies include:

- **Fine-needle aspiration** and **core needle biopsy** use needles of different sizes to remove a sample of tissue or fluid.
- **Vacuum-assisted core biopsy** uses suction through a needle to remove the sample.
- **Excisional biopsy** removes the entire abnormal area. This isn't the preferred type of biopsy, but it may be necessary if other methods aren't possible or the biopsy results don't match the expected findings. An excisional biopsy is usually done using anesthesia in an operating room.

Before a biopsy, the area is injected with numbing medicine. A core needle biopsy removes more than 1 tissue sample, but usually through the same area on the breast. The samples are small. The needle is often guided into the tumor with imaging. When mammography is used during a biopsy, it's called a stereotactic needle biopsy.

2 Testing for invasive breast cancer

One or more clips may be placed near the breast tumor during a biopsy. The clips are small, painless, and made of metal. They mark the site for future treatment and imaging. The clips stay in place until surgery. If the area biopsied is benign, the clips remain in place to mark the biopsy site in future imaging. The clips cause no problems, even if they're left in place for a long time. You'll be able to go through airport security and have an MRI.

Axillary lymph node needle biopsy

Axillary lymph nodes are found near the armpit. These lymph nodes drain lymph fluid from the breast and nearby areas. In an axillary lymph node biopsy, a sample of lymph node near the armpit is biopsied with a needle. This is done to determine if abnormal lymph nodes seen on imaging tests contain cancer cells. An ultrasound-guided fine-needle aspiration or core needle biopsy will be used. If cancer is found, it's called node positive

(node+). A marker may be placed in the node so that it can be identified later if needed.

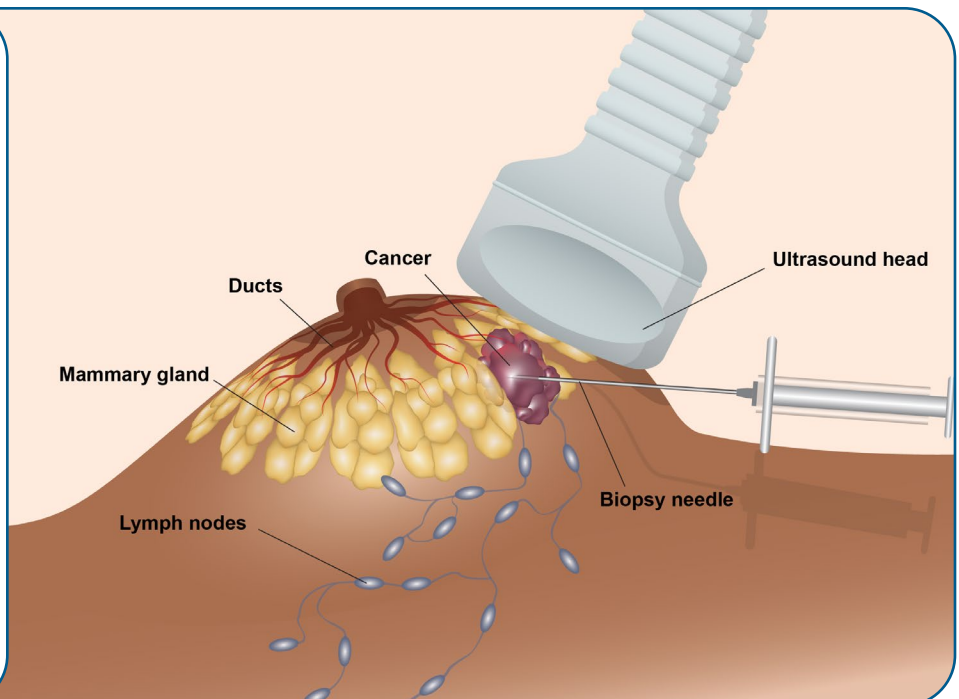
Biopsy results

Your pathology report will contain information about tumor histology and grade (how abnormal the tumor looks). Histology is the study of the anatomy (structure) of cells, tissues, and organs under a microscope. It's used to make treatment decisions.

The tissue removed may be benign (not cancer), atypical (not typical), or cancerous. If the tissue is benign, this area may be observed. If the tissue is atypical, a surgical (open) biopsy of the area may be recommended for further evaluation. If tissue shows cancer, your health care provider will discuss next steps.

Biopsy

In a biopsy, a sample of tumor is removed. There are different types of biopsy. This image shows an ultrasound-guided needle biopsy.



HER2 status

Breast cancer can produce greater than normal amounts of human epidermal growth factor receptor 2 (HER2). HER2 is a protein involved in normal cell growth. It's found on the surface of all cells. When amounts are high, it causes cells to grow and divide. Some breast cancers have too many HER2 genes or receptors. This is called HER2-positive (HER2+) breast cancer. You might hear it called HER2 overexpression or amplification.

There are 2 tests for HER2:

- **Immunohistochemistry (IHC)** measures receptors. If the score is 0 or 1, it's considered HER2-negative (HER2-). If the score is 2+, further testing is needed. If the IHC score is 3+, the cancer is HER2+ (with FISH-positive). Additionally, another term you may hear is HER2-low, which means HER2 1+ and 2+ (with FISH-negative).
- **Fluorescence in situ hybridization (FISH)** counts the number of copies of the *HER2* gene. This test is done mainly when the IHC score is unclear.

HER2 testing should be done on all new tumors. A tumor biopsy sample will be used. You might have more than one HER2 test.



Treatment options by cell receptor type

There are many treatments for breast cancer. Which ones are right for you are based on many factors. **Two important factors are the hormone receptor (HR) and HER2 status of any tumors.**

- Hormone receptors include estrogen and progesterone. A tumor is considered hormone receptor-positive (HR+) if an increased number of estrogen receptors, progesterone receptors, or both are found.
- HER2 is a protein involved in normal cell growth. There might be higher amounts of HER2 in your breast cancer. If this is the case, it's called HER2-positive (HER2+) breast cancer.

Endocrine therapy stops cancer growth caused by hormones. It's a standard treatment for hormone receptor-positive (HR+) cancers. HR+ cancer can be estrogen receptor-positive (ER+), progesterone receptor-positive (PR+), or both (ER+/PR+).

HER2-targeted therapy is a standard treatment for HER2+ cancers.

Other systemic therapies are used with those listed above to treat invasive breast cancer.

Immunohistochemistry

Immunohistochemistry is a special staining process that involves adding a chemical marker to cancer or immune cells. The cells are then studied using a microscope. IHC can find estrogen, progesterone, and HER2 receptors in breast cancer cells. A pathologist will measure the number of cells with estrogen or progesterone receptors and the number of receptors inside each cell.

FISH or ISH

FISH, or other ISH methods like dual ISH, are testing methods that involve special dyes called probes that attach to pieces of DNA. DNA is the genetic material in a person's cells.

Hormone receptor status

Estrogen and progesterone are examples of hormones. A hormone is a substance made by a gland in your body. Hormones attach or bind to receptors found on the surface or inside certain cells.

When estrogen and progesterone attach to receptors found inside breast cancer cells, they can cause cancer to grow. Hormone receptor testing looks for estrogen and progesterone receptors in breast cancer cells. If found, these receptors may be targeted using endocrine (hormone-blocking) therapy.

Breast cancers can be hormone receptor-positive (HR+) or hormone receptor-negative (HR-). Hormone receptor testing should be done on any new tumors. A biopsy sample will be used.

Estrogen receptor-positive (ER+) breast cancer cells

- In ER+ breast cancer, testing finds estrogen hormone receptors in at least 1 out of every 100 cancer cells.
- In ER-low-positive invasive breast cancer, testing finds estrogen hormone receptors in 1 to 10 out of every 100 cancer cells.

Hormone receptor-positive

In hormone receptor-positive (HR+), or hormone-sensitive, breast cancer, IHC finds estrogen receptors (ER+), progesterone hormone receptors (PR+), or both (ER+/PR+). Most breast cancers are ER+/PR+ or ER+/PR-. An ER-/PR+ tumor is relatively uncommon.

HR+ breast cancer is treated with endocrine therapy, which blocks estrogen receptor signaling or decreases estrogen production.

Hormone receptor-negative

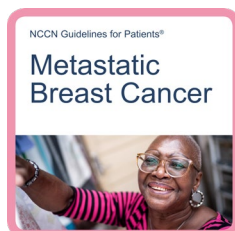
Hormone receptor-negative (HR-) breast cancer cells don't have estrogen or progesterone hormone receptors. These cancers are sometimes simply called hormone negative. HR- cancers often grow faster than HR+ cancers. Both the estrogen and progesterone receptors need to be negative for breast cancer to be considered HR-.

Biomarker testing

HER2 and hormone receptor status are part of biomarker testing. Your treatment team will recommend the best types of biomarker testing for you.

Biomarker testing includes tests of genes or their products (proteins). It identifies the presence or absence of mutations and certain proteins that might suggest treatment. Proteins are written like this: BRCA. Genes are written with italics like this: *BRCA*.

Mutation testing is more commonly done in metastatic breast cancer. For more information, see *NCCN Guidelines for Patients: Metastatic Breast Cancer* at [NCCN.org/patientguidelines](https://www.nccn.org/patientguidelines) and on the [NCCN Patient Guides for Cancer](#) app.



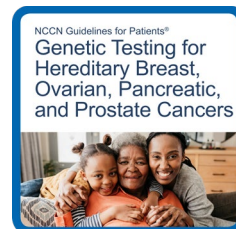
Genetic cancer risk testing

About 1 out of 20 breast cancers are hereditary, which means they are passed down from birth parents through DNA. Depending on your family history or other features of your cancer, your health care provider might refer you for genetic counseling and hereditary genetic testing to learn more about your cancer. A genetic counselor or trained provider will speak with you about the results. Test results may guide treatment planning.

Genetic testing is done using blood or saliva. The goal is to look for gene mutations inherited from your biological (birth) parents, called germline mutations. Some mutations can put you at risk of more than 1 type of cancer. You

can pass these genes on to your children. Also, other family members might carry these mutations. Tell your care team if there's a family history of cancer.

More information on genetic cancer risk testing can be found in *NCCN Guidelines for Patients: Genetic Testing for Hereditary Breast, Ovarian, Pancreatic, and Prostate Cancers* at [NCCN.org/patientguidelines](https://www.nccn.org/patientguidelines) and on the [NCCN Patient Guides for Cancer](#) app.



BRCA mutation tests

Everyone has *BRCA* genes. Normal *BRCA* genes help to prevent tumor growth, help fix damaged cells, and help cells grow normally. However, mutations in *BRCA1* or *BRCA2* increase the risk of breast, ovarian, prostate, colorectal, pancreatic, and melanoma skin cancers. Mutated *BRCA* genes can also affect how some treatments work.

The technology for genetic testing has improved, so if you tested negative for a gene mutation over 10 years ago, you may be re-tested.

Other genes that might be tested

Other genes, such as *PALB2*, *p53*, *CHEK2*, and *ATM*, might be tested. For example, *PALB2* normally helps prevent cancer. When *PALB2* mutates, it no longer works correctly. People with a *PALB2* mutation have a higher risk of developing breast cancer.

Key points

- Not all breast cancers are the same. Treatment planning starts with testing. Results from a tumor biopsy and imaging studies will be used to determine what treatments are best for your type of breast cancer.
- A diagnostic mammogram includes detailed pictures of one or both breasts. It's different from a screening mammogram.
- During a biopsy, tissue or fluid samples are removed for testing. Samples are needed to confirm the presence of cancer and to perform cancer cell tests.
- A sample from a biopsy of your tumor will be tested for estrogen receptor (ER) status, progesterone receptor (PR) status, HER2 status, and histology. This provides information about the behavior of your cancer, as well as treatments to which your cancer may respond.
- Treatment can affect your fertility, or the ability to have children. You might be referred to a fertility specialist to discuss fertility preservation.
- About 1 out of 20 breast cancers are hereditary. Depending on your family history or other features of your cancer, your health care provider might refer you for hereditary genetic testing or to a genetic counselor.

Questions to ask

- What type(s) of imaging scans will I have?
- What type of biopsy will I have?
- What tests will be done on the tumor?
- When will the test results be ready and who will discuss them with me?
- What is the tumor HER2 and hormone receptor (HR) status?

What's next?

The next chapter provides information on how breast cancer is staged.



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3

Breast cancer staging

- 22 How is breast cancer staged?
- 24 TNM scores
- 25 Breast cancer stages
- 26 Key points
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3 Breast cancer staging

Cancer staging is used to guide treatment decisions. It describes the size and location of the tumor and if cancer has spread to lymph nodes, organs, or other parts of the body. It also considers hormone receptor (HR) and HER2 status, and standard-of-care treatment results.

Most invasive breast cancers are invasive ductal carcinomas. This is cancer that started in the cells that line the milk ducts and has spread into surrounding tissue.

More information about how breast cancer is staged is explained next.

How is breast cancer staged?

A cancer stage is a way to describe the extent of the cancer when you're first diagnosed. Based on testing, your cancer will be assigned a stage. Staging helps to predict prognosis and is needed to make treatment decisions. A prognosis is the course your cancer will likely take.

Information gathered during staging:

- **The extent (size) of the tumor (T):** How large is the cancer? Has it grown into nearby areas?
- **The spread to nearby lymph nodes (N):** Has the cancer spread to nearby lymph nodes? If yes, then this is at least stage 2 or 3 breast cancer. How many lymph nodes have cancer? Where?
- **The spread (metastasis) to distant sites (M):** Has the cancer spread to distant organs, such as bones, lungs, liver? If yes, then this is considered metastatic disease or stage 4 breast cancer.
- **Hormone receptor (HR) status:** Does the cancer have estrogen receptors (ER) or progesterone receptors (PR)?
- **HER2 status:** Does the cancer make too much of a protein called HER2?
- **Grade of the cancer (G):** How much do the cancer cells look like normal cells?
- **Biomarker testing:** Does the cancer have any genes, proteins, markers, or mutations that might suggest treatment?

Staging is based on a combination of information to reach a numbered stage. It takes into account what can be felt during a physical exam, what can be seen on imaging tests, and what is found during a biopsy or surgery. Often, not all information is available at the initial evaluation. More information can be gathered as treatment begins.

3 Breast cancer staging

Staging includes:

- **Anatomic** – Based on extent of cancer as defined by tumor size (T), lymph node status (N), and distant metastasis (M).
- **Prognostic** – Includes anatomic TNM plus tumor grade and the status of the biomarkers such as human epidermal growth factor receptor 2 (HER2), estrogen receptor (ER), and progesterone receptor (PR). Prognostic stage also assumes you're being treated with the standard-of-care approaches.

Breast cancer staging is often done twice, before and after surgery. Staging after surgery provides more specific and accurate details about the size of the cancer and lymph node status.

Clinical stage

Clinical stage (c) is the rating given before any treatment. An example might look like cT1 or cN2. In breast cancer, the clinical stage is based on imaging and biopsy results. These tests are done as part of an initial diagnosis or before any treatment.

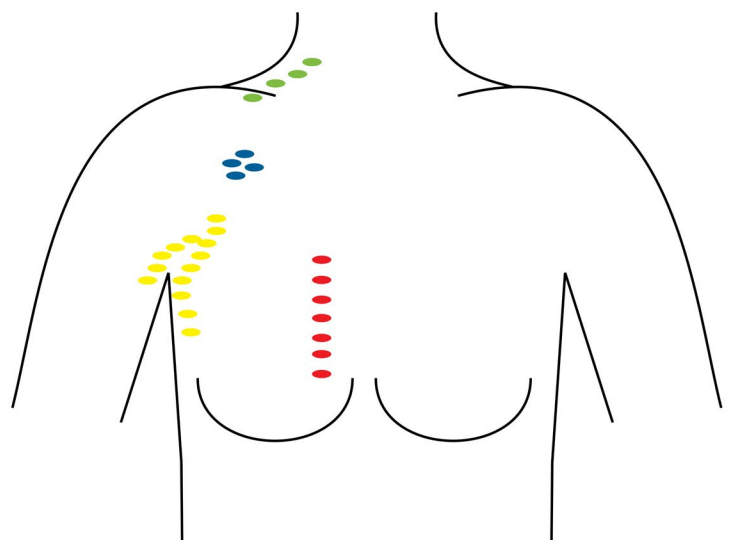
Pathologic stage

Pathologic stage (p), or surgical stage, is determined by examining tissue removed during surgery. An example might be pN2. If you are given drug therapy before surgery, then the stage might add a y and look like ypT3.

Clinical staging

Clinical staging of lymph nodes is staging before surgery.

- Cancer is in axillary nodes
- Cancer is in internal mammary nodes
- Cancer is in infraclavicular nodes
- Cancer is in supraclavicular nodes



TNM scores

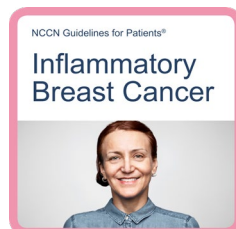
The tumor, node, and metastasis (TNM) system is used to stage breast cancer. In this system, the letters T, N, and M describe different areas of cancer growth. Based on cancer test results, a score or number is assigned to each letter. The higher the number, the larger the tumor or the more the cancer has spread. These scores are combined to assign the cancer a stage. A TNM example might look like this: T3N2M0 or T3, N2, M0.

T = Tumor

T describes the depth and size of the main tumor in 1 or both breasts. Tumor size can be measured in centimeters (cm) or millimeters (mm). One inch is equal to 2.54 cm. For comparison, a large pea is 1 cm (10 mm) and a golf ball is 4 cm (40 mm). A tumor micrometastasis is a very small collection of cancerous cells smaller than 1 mm. It might be written as T1mi. Ipsilateral means on the same side of the body.

- **T1** – Tumor is 2 cm (20 mm) or less
- **T2** – Tumor is 2.1 cm to 5 cm
- **T3** – Tumor is more than 5 cm
- **T4** – Tumor is of any size and has invaded nearby structures, such as the chest wall and skin of the breast
- **T4d** – Tumor is inflammatory carcinoma (inflammatory breast cancer)

For more information on inflammatory breast cancer, see *NCCN Guidelines for Patients: Inflammatory Breast Cancer* at [NCCN.org/patientguidelines](https://www.nccn.org/patientguidelines) and on the [NCCN Patient Guides for Cancer](#) app.



N = Regional lymph node

Regional lymph nodes are located near the breast in the armpit (axilla). If breast cancer spreads, it often goes first to nearby lymph nodes under the arm. It can also sometimes spread to lymph nodes near the collarbone or near the breastbone. However, it's possible for cancerous cells to travel through lymph and blood to other parts of the body without having gone to the lymph nodes first. Knowing if the cancer has spread to your lymph nodes helps doctors find the best way to treat your cancer.

- **N0** – No cancer is found in the regional lymph nodes. Isolated tumor cells may be present. These are malignant cell clusters no larger than 0.2 mm.
- **N1mi** – Micrometastases (approximately 200 cells, larger than 0.2 mm but not larger than 2.0 mm) are found in lymph nodes.
- **N1, N2, N3** – Regional lymph node metastases are found. The higher the number, the more lymph nodes that have metastases.

M = Metastasis

Metastasis is cancer that has spread to distant parts of the body. This is metastatic breast cancer. The most common sites for metastasis are bone, lung, and liver.

Grade

Grade describes how abnormal tumor cells look under a microscope (called histology). Higher-grade cancers tend to grow and spread faster than lower-grade cancers. G3 is the highest grade for breast cancers. A low-grade tumor has a low risk of returning (called recurrence). A high-grade tumor has a higher risk of recurrence.

- **GX** – Grade cannot be determined
- **G1** – Low
- **G2** – Intermediate
- **G3** – High

Breast cancer stages

Numbered stages are based on TNM scores and receptor (hormone and HER2) status. Stages range from stage 0 to stage 4, with 4 being the most advanced. They might be written as stage 0, stage I, stage II, stage III, and stage IV. Invasive breast cancer can be stage 1, 2, or 3.

- **Stage 0 is noninvasive** – Noninvasive breast cancer hasn't spread to the surrounding breast tissue, lymph nodes, or distant sites.
- **Stages 1, 2, and 3 are invasive but not metastatic** – Invasive breast cancer has grown outside the ducts, lobules, or breast skin. Cancer might be in the axillary lymph nodes.
- **Stage 4 is metastatic** – In stage 4 breast cancer, cancer has spread to distant sites. It can develop from earlier stages. Sometimes, the first diagnosis is stage 4 metastatic breast cancer (called de novo).

Key points

- Cancer staging is used to guide treatment decisions.
- The tumor, node, and metastasis (TNM) system is used to stage breast cancer.
- Breast cancer is often staged twice, before and after surgery.
- Clinical stage is the rating given before any treatment.
- Pathologic stage, or surgical stage, is determined by examining tissue removed during surgery.
- Grade describes how abnormal the tumor cells look under a microscope (called histology).
- Regional lymph nodes are found near the breast. If breast cancer spreads, it often goes first to nearby lymph nodes under the arm.

Questions to ask

- What is the cancer stage and tumor grade?
- What does the cancer stage and grade mean in terms of treatment options and prognosis?
- Is there more than one known cancer site?
- Is cancer in the lymph nodes? If so, which ones?
- What is the tumor HER2 and hormone status?

What's next?

The next chapter provides information on the types of treatment and what to expect from treatment.



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4

Types of treatment

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4 Types of treatment

There's more than 1 treatment for breast cancer. Treatment is usually a combination of surgery and other therapies. This chapter provides an overview of treatment options and what to expect from treatment.

Your care team

Treating cancer takes a team approach. Treatment decisions should involve a team of health care and psychosocial care professionals from different backgrounds who have knowledge and experience in your type of cancer. This team is united in planning and implementing your treatment.

Treatment overview

Invasive breast cancer is treatable. It might be treated with a combination of surgery, drug (systemic) therapy, and radiation therapy. Systemic therapy is based on tumor estrogen receptor (ER), progesterone receptor (PR), and HER2 expression.

Many factors play a role in how your cancer will respond to treatment. It's important to have regular talks with your care team about your goals for treatment and your treatment plan.

Breast surgery

Surgery is an operation or procedure to remove cancer from the body. When preparing for surgery, seek the opinion of an experienced surgeon who is an expert in your type of surgery. Hospitals that perform many surgeries often have better results. You can ask for a referral to a hospital or cancer center that has experience in treating your type of cancer. Sometimes treatment is needed before surgery.

Goal of surgery

The goal of surgery is to remove all of the cancer. To do this, the tumor is removed along with an area of normal-looking tissue called the surgical margin. The surgical margin may look normal during surgery, but cancerous cells may be found when viewed under a microscope by a pathologist. In a negative, or clear, margin, no cancer cells are found in the tissue around the edge of the tumor. In a positive margin, cancer cells are found around the edge of the tumor area.

After surgery, you may receive treatment such as radiation to kill any remaining cancer cells. You might have a wound drain to prevent fluid from collecting in the body after surgery. These drains are usually removed a few days after surgery.

4 Types of treatment

Lumpectomy (or partial mastectomy)

A lumpectomy, or partial mastectomy, is the removal of breast tissue containing cancerous cells and/or a tumor. It doesn't remove the whole breast. A lumpectomy is also called breast-conserving therapy or breast-conserving surgery.

In a lumpectomy, the surgeon aims to remove all of the tumor with a rim of healthy tissue around it, called a negative, or clear, surgical margin. Having a negative surgical margin decreases the chance that cancer will return in that area of the breast. You may need more than 1 surgery to achieve negative margins and ensure all the cancer is removed. A lumpectomy is usually followed by radiation therapy to part or all of the breast.

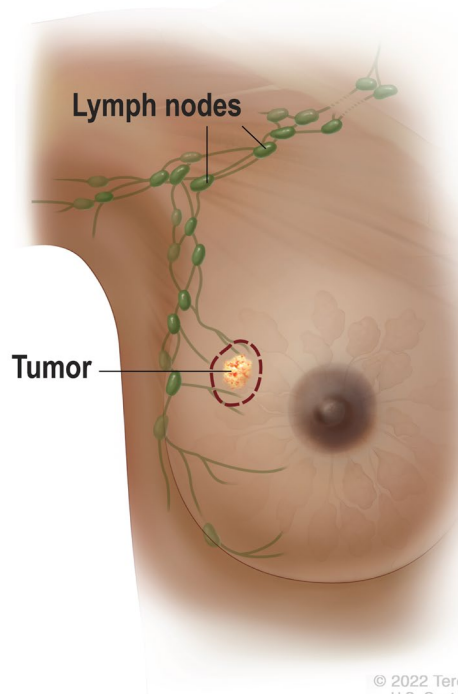
The breast might not look the same after a lumpectomy. Speak to your surgeon about how a lumpectomy might affect the look and shape of your breast and any other concerns you have. You can also seek the opinion of a plastic surgeon.

Mastectomy

A mastectomy removes the whole breast. In some cases, the surgeon may do a sentinel lymph node biopsy before removing the breast (see the next section). Sentinel lymph nodes are the first lymph nodes where cancer cells are likely to have spread from the primary tumor.

Lumpectomy

Lumpectomy is the removal of abnormal cells or tumor (dotted line) and not the whole breast. It's also called a partial mastectomy, breast-conserving therapy, or breast-conserving surgery.



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4 Types of treatment

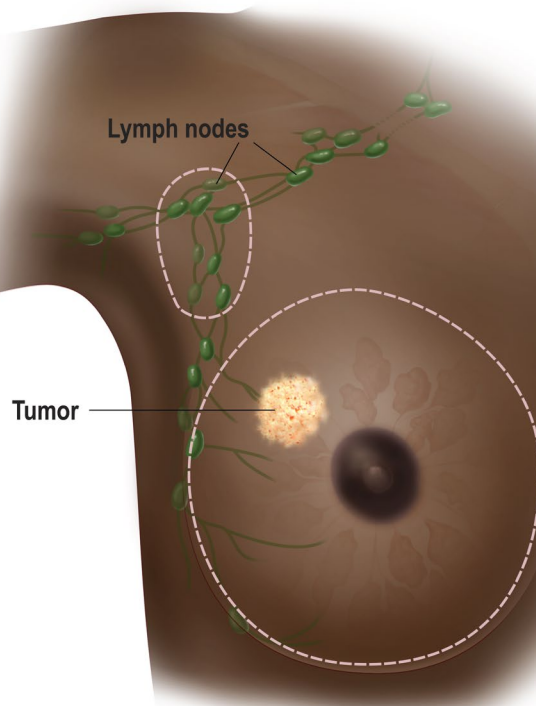
Types of mastectomies include:

- **Total mastectomy, or simple mastectomy** – Removes the whole breast with a flat skin closure.
- **Modified radical mastectomy** – Removes the breast and axillary lymph nodes.
- **Skin-sparing mastectomy** – Removes the breast but not all of the skin so you can have breast reconstruction that might include flaps and/or implants, with nipple reconstruction as an option.
- **Nipple-sparing mastectomy** – Preserves the nipple-areola complex as well as all of the skin. Not everyone is a candidate for nipple-sparing mastectomy based upon location of cancer, breast size, and breast ptosis (degree of drooping).

Breast reconstruction is an option after a mastectomy. If you opt for reconstruction, it can be done during the initial surgery to remove your breast or after finishing cancer treatment. If it's done after cancer treatment, this is called delayed reconstruction. Breast reconstruction is often done in multiple stages. The first stage occurs at the same time as mastectomy, but you'll have multiple subsequent surgeries to achieve the desired long-term result. You'll need to consult with a reconstructive (plastic) surgeon.

Total (simple) mastectomy

In a total mastectomy, the entire breast is removed (dotted line). Some lymph nodes under the arm may also be removed.



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Lymph node surgery

This section explains 2 types of lymph node surgery that might be done at the time of a mastectomy.

Sentinel lymph node biopsy

Sentinel lymph node biopsy is done during a mastectomy to determine if any cancer cells have traveled to the lymph nodes.

Sentinel lymph nodes are the first lymph nodes where cancer cells are likely to spread from the main cancer area. Removal of the sentinel lymph nodes during surgery is called a sentinel lymph node biopsy (SLNB). This procedure is done to determine if any cancer cells have traveled to the lymph nodes. Just because these nodes are removed doesn't mean they are positive for cancer.

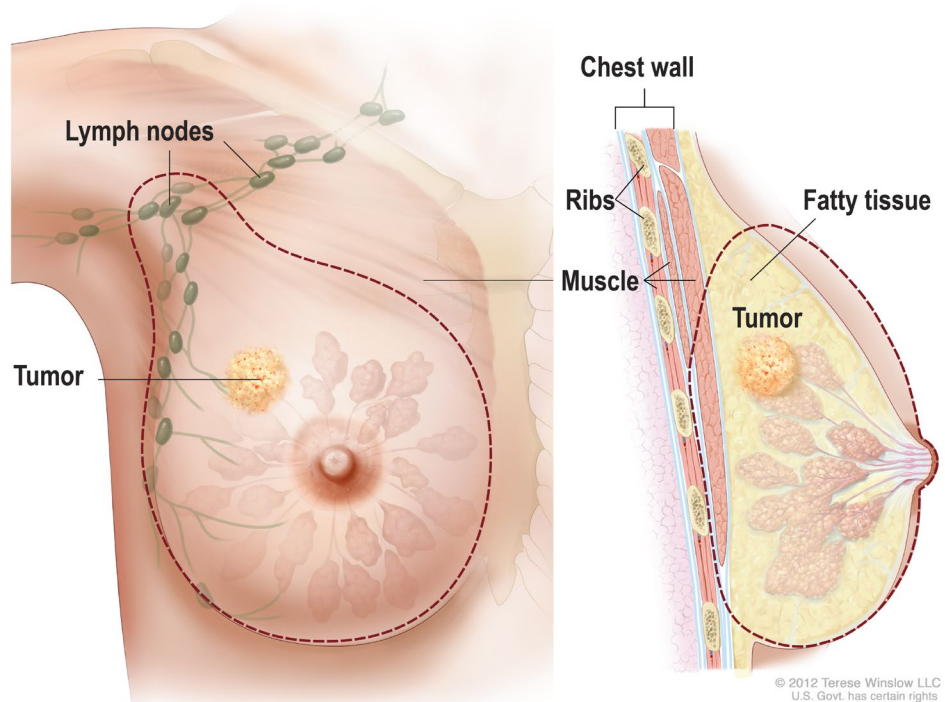
To find the sentinel lymph nodes, radioactive material and other dyes are injected into the breast. The injected materials then travel through the lymphatics in the breast to the lymph nodes. This helps the surgeon find the sentinel lymph nodes. The nodes containing the radioactive material or dye are removed and tested by a pathologist. If cancer is found, then more lymph nodes may be removed.

Axillary lymph node dissection

Axillary lymph node dissection (ALND) is surgery to remove lymph nodes near the armpit. This is performed after an axillary lymph node biopsy or a sentinel lymph node biopsy shows cancer in the lymph nodes, called node positive (node+). An ALND will remove any other lymph nodes that contain cancer. Removing lymph nodes can cause lymphedema of the arm (chronic fluid buildup) and other health issues.

Modified radical mastectomy

In a modified radical mastectomy, the entire breast and some lymph nodes are removed (dotted line).



4 Types of treatment

When the axillary nodes are removed with the breast, it's called a modified radical mastectomy.

There are 3 levels of axillary lymph nodes:

- **Level I** – Nodes located below the lower edge of the chest muscle
- **Level II** – Nodes located underneath the chest muscle
- **Level III** – Nodes located above the chest muscle near the collarbone

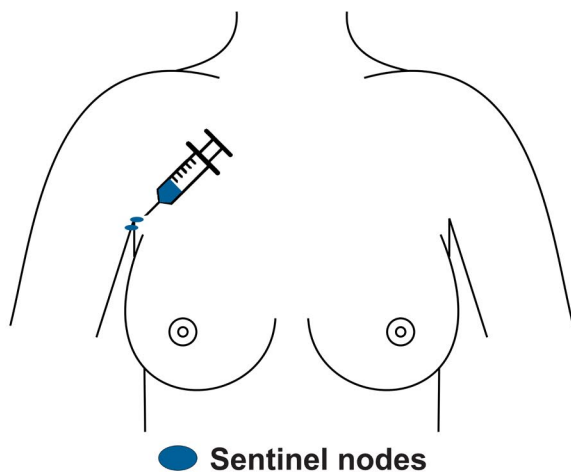
An ALND usually removes level I and II axillary lymph nodes. Level III nodes are not typically removed unless there's a lot of disease. For more information about the timing of biopsies, talk with your care team.

Radiation therapy

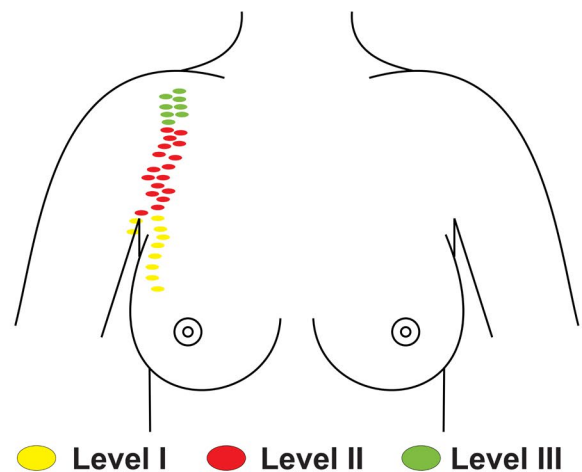
Radiation therapy (RT) uses high-energy radiation from x-rays (photons), protons, and other sources to kill any cancer cells that remain after surgery.

You'll see your radiation oncologist at least weekly to discuss treatment results and to help with any side effects, such as a sunburn-like rash. Ask your care team which radiation option(s) are best for your situation, if radiation therapy will be combined with drug therapy, and what side effects to expect.

Sentinel lymph node biopsy



Axillary lymph node dissection



4 Types of treatment

The following are types of radiation therapy used to treat breast cancer:

- **Whole breast radiation therapy** is used to treat the entire breast.
- **Partial breast irradiation** is used to treat only the tumor area of the breast.
- **Postmastectomy radiation therapy** is given after a mastectomy. It targets the chest wall and possible mastectomy scar.

Radiation therapy may be given to the breast and chest wall, below or above the collarbone, lymph nodes found inside the breast, behind the ribcage, or armpit area.

External beam radiation therapy

External beam radiation therapy (EBRT) uses a machine outside of the body called a linear accelerator (linac) to aim radiation at the whole breast (called whole breast radiation therapy or WBRT) and lymph nodes (called regional nodal irradiation or RNI).

Internal radiation

Internal radiation (brachytherapy) involves placing one or more small tubes into the tumor area of the breast. A small radioactive seed travels into the tube(s) and delivers radiation to the tumor area of the breast from inside the body. This type of radiation is used only for partial breast radiation therapy.



Warnings about supplements and drug interactions

Some supplements and foods can affect the ability of a drug used to treat breast cancer to do its job. This is called a drug interaction. Since there's often a lack of published information about how certain supplements interact with standard medicines, your care team may recommend that many of them be discontinued during treatment.

Also, certain medicines can affect the ability of a drug to do its job. Antacids, heart or blood pressure medicine, and antidepressants are just some of the medicines that might interact with systemic therapy or supportive care medicines given during systemic drug therapy.

Therefore, it's very important to tell your care team about any medicines, vitamins, over-the-counter drugs, herbals, or supplements you're taking.

Bring a list with you to every visit.

Systemic therapy

Systemic therapy is drug therapy that works throughout the body. It's 1 part of an invasive breast cancer treatment plan.

All systemic treatments listed in this guide are recommended and appropriate. Some therapies are only used for advanced or metastatic breast cancer. When helpful, NCCN experts also assign a level of preference to their recommendations for systemic therapies:

- **Preferred therapies** have the most evidence they may work better and may be safer than other therapies.
- **Other recommended therapies** can provide effective results but may have less evidence, more side effects, or may not work quite as well as preferred therapies.
- **Therapies used in certain cases** work best for individuals with specific cancer features or health circumstances.

For a general list of systemic therapies, see **Guide 2**.

Systemic therapy might be used alone or with other therapies. Goals of systemic therapy should be discussed before starting treatment.

The choice of therapy takes into consideration many factors, including HER2 and hormone receptor tumor status, if the tumor can be removed with surgery (resectable), your preferences about treatment, and if you have any other serious health conditions.

Systemic therapy might be given before or after surgery. Systemic therapies are described in more detail below and in the following pages.

Chemotherapy

Chemotherapy kills fast-dividing cells throughout the body, including cancer cells and some normal cells. More than 1 chemotherapy may be used to treat invasive breast cancer. When only 1 drug is used, it's called a single agent. A combination or multi-agent regimen is the use of 2 or more chemotherapy drugs.

Some chemotherapy drugs are liquids given through a vein or injected under the skin with a needle. Other chemotherapy drugs may be given as a pill that's swallowed.

Most chemotherapy is given in cycles of days of treatment followed by days of rest. This allows the body to recover before the next cycle. Cycles vary in length depending on which drugs are used. The number of treatment days per cycle and the total number of cycles given also vary.

Antibody drug conjugates

An antibody drug conjugate (ADC) delivers cell-specific chemotherapy. It attaches to a protein found on the outside of the cancer cell, then enters the cell. Once inside the cell, chemotherapy is released. ADCs are given in cycles. Some ADCs target HER2.

HER2-targeted therapy

When breast cancer has higher amounts of HER2, it's called HER2-positive (HER2+) breast cancer.

HER2-targeted therapy treats HER2+ breast cancer. Some HER2-targeted therapy is given

Guide 2

Systemic therapy examples (listed in alphabetical order)

Chemotherapy	• Capecitabine (Xeloda) • Carboplatin (Kyxata) • Cisplatin • Cyclophosphamide (Frindovyx) • Docetaxel • Doxorubicin (Doxi) • Epirubicin (Ellence) • Eribulin (Halaven) • Fluorouracil • Gemcitabine (Avgemsi) • Methotrexate • Paclitaxel • Vinorelbine
Antibody drug conjugate (ADC)	• Ado-trastuzumab emtansine (T-DM1) (Kadcyla) • Datopotamab deruxtecan-dlnk (Datroway) • Fam-trastuzumab deruxtecan-nxki (T-DXd) (Enhertu) • Sacituzumab govitecan-hziy (Trodelvy)
Targeted therapy (these don't target HER2)	CDK4/6 inhibitors • Abemaciclib (Verzenio), Palbociclib (Ibrance), and Ribociclib (Kisqali)
	PARP inhibitors • Olaparib (Lynparza) and Talazoparib (Talzenna)
	PIK3CA, AKT1, PTEN, ROS1, TRK, mTOR, and other inhibitors • Alpelisib (Piqray), Capivasertib (Truqap), Entrectinib (Entrectinib), Erdafitinib (Balversa), Everolimus (Afinitor), Inavolisib (Itovebi), Larotrectinib (Vitrakvi), Repotrectinib (Augtyro), and Selpercatinib (Retevmo)
HER2-targeting therapy	Antibodies • Margetuximab-cmkb (Margenza) • Pertuzumab (Perjeta) and its substitutes called biosimilars • Trastuzumab (Herceptin) and biosimilars
	ADCs • Ado-trastuzumab emtansine and Fam-trastuzumab deruxtecan-nxki
	Inhibitors • Lapatinib (Tykerb), Neratinib (Nerlynx), and Tucatinib (Tukysa)
Immunotherapy	• Pembrolizumab (Keytruda) and Dostarlimab-gxly (Jemperli)
Endocrine therapy	• Endocrine therapy can be found in Guide 3.

4 Types of treatment

with chemotherapy. However, it might be used alone or combined with endocrine therapy.

HER2-targeted therapies include:

- **HER2 antibodies** prevent HER2 growth signals from outside the cell. They also help immune cells attack cancer cells.
- **HER2 inhibitors** stop HER2 growth signals from within the cell.
- **HER2 conjugates or HER2 antibody drug conjugates (ADCs)** deliver cell-specific chemotherapy. They attach directly to HER2s then enter the cell. Once inside, chemotherapy is released.

Your heart will be monitored before and during treatment with HER2-targeted therapy. Tests will measure the left ventricular ejection fraction, the amount of blood pumping from the left side of the heart.

Other targeted therapies

This section discusses inhibitors that are different from inhibitors used in HER2-targeted therapy.

CDK4/6 inhibitors

CDK is a cell protein that helps cells grow and divide. For hormone receptor-positive (HR+), HER2-negative (HER2-) cancer, taking a CDK4/6 inhibitor with endocrine therapy may help control cancer longer and improve survival. CDK4/6 inhibitors include abemaciclib, palbociclib, and ribociclib.

PARP inhibitors

Cancer cells often become damaged. PARP is a cell protein that repairs cancer cells and allows them to survive. Blocking PARP can cause cancer cells to die. Olaparib and talazoparib are examples of PARP inhibitors (PARPi).

The best-known way to treat a particular disease based on past clinical trials is called standard of care. There may be more than one treatment considered standard of care. Ask your care team what treatment options are available and if a clinical trial might be right for you.



PIK3CA, PTEN, AKT1, and other inhibitors

The *PIK3CA* gene is one of the most frequently mutated genes in breast cancers. *PTEN* and *AKT1* can also be altered in breast cancers. A mutation or alteration in these genes can lead to increased growth of cancer cells and resistance to various treatments. Alpelisib and inavolisib are examples of a PIK3CA inhibitor and capivasertib is an AKT1 inhibitor.

mTOR inhibitors

mTOR is a cell protein that helps cells grow and divide. Endocrine therapy may stop working if mTOR becomes overactive. mTOR inhibitors help endocrine therapy work again.

Everolimus (Afinitor) is an mTOR inhibitor. It's usually taken with exemestane. For some, it may be taken with fulvestrant or tamoxifen.

Immunotherapy

Immunotherapy tries to reactivate the immune system against tumor cells. The immune system has many on and off switches. Tumors take advantage of off switches. Immunotherapy can block these off switches, which helps the immune system turn on. Immunotherapy can be given alone or with other types of treatment. Pembrolizumab and dostarlimab-gxly are immunotherapies.

Endocrine therapy

Endocrine therapy blocks estrogen or progesterone to treat hormone receptor-positive (HR+) breast cancer. The endocrine system is made up of organs and tissues that produce hormones. Hormones are natural chemicals released into the bloodstream.

There are 4 hormones that might be targeted in endocrine therapy:

- **Estrogen** is made mainly by the ovaries but is also made by other tissues in the body such as fat tissue.
- **Progesterone** is made mainly by the ovaries.
- **Luteinizing hormone-releasing hormone (LHRH)** is made by a part of the brain called the hypothalamus. It tells the ovaries to make estrogen and progesterone and testicles to make testosterone. LHRH is also called gonadotropin-releasing hormone (GnRH).
- **Androgen** is made by the adrenal glands, testicles, and ovaries.

Hormones may cause breast cancer to grow. Endocrine therapy stops your body from making hormones or blocks what hormones do in the body. This can slow cancer growth, shrink the cancer for a period of time, or prevent the cancer from returning.

Endocrine therapy is sometimes called hormone therapy or anti-estrogen therapy. It's different from hormone replacement therapy (HRT) used for menopause.

4 Types of treatment

Endocrine therapy suppresses hormone production and affects the ability to become pregnant. People who want to have children in the future should be referred to a fertility specialist before starting endocrine therapy. Endocrine therapy usually lasts a minimum of 5 years but can continue for up to 10 years.

Types of endocrine therapy can be found in **Guide 3**.

Guide 3

Endocrine therapy types

Bilateral oophorectomy	Surgery to remove both ovaries
Ovarian ablation	Radiation to permanently stop the ovaries from making hormones
Ovarian or testosterone suppression	Drugs to temporarily stop the ovaries or testicles from making hormones, such as LHRH and GnRH • LHRH agonists include Goserelin (Zoladex) and Leuprolide (Lupron Depot). These are injected every 4 or 12 weeks. They don't affect estrogen made by the ovaries • GnRH agonists might be used to suppress ovarian hormone or testosterone production
Aromatase inhibitors (AIs)	Drugs to stop a type of hormone called androgen from changing into estrogen by interfering with an enzyme called aromatase. AIs don't affect estrogen made by the ovaries. Nonsteroidal AIs include Anastrozole (Arimidex) and Letrozole (Femara). Exemestane (Aromasin) is a steroidal AI
Estrogen receptor (ER) modulators or anti-estrogens	• Selective estrogen receptor modulators (SERMs) block estrogen from attaching to hormone receptors. Tamoxifen and Toremifene (Fareston) are SERMs • Selective estrogen receptor degraders (SERDs) block and destroy estrogen receptors. Elacestrant (Orserdu), Fulvestrant (Faslodex), and Imlunestrant (Inluriyo) are SERDs
Hormones	Examples include Estradiol, Fluoxymesterone, and Megestrol acetate (Megace)

4 Types of treatment

Testosterone

For people assigned male at birth whose bodies continue to make testosterone, endocrine therapy includes tamoxifen or an aromatase inhibitor with a testosterone-suppressing therapy.

Premenopause

If you have menstrual periods, you're in premenopause. In premenopause, the ovaries are the main source of estrogen and progesterone.

- Tamoxifen or a combination of GnRH agonists and aromatase inhibitors (AIs) are the 2 main choices for endocrine treatment for people in premenopause.
- GnRH agonists may be used to temporarily induce menopause.
- A combination of GnRH agonists and tamoxifen or AIs may be given.
- Ovarian suppression or ablation is frequently considered for higher-risk ER+ breast cancers.

Menopause

In menopause, the ovaries permanently stop producing hormones and menstrual periods stop. Estrogen and progesterone levels are low, but the adrenal glands, liver, and body fat continue to make small amounts of estrogen. If you don't have periods, a test using a blood sample may be used to confirm your status.

If you stopped having periods due to removal of your uterus (hysterectomy) but you still have your ovaries, then you should have your menopausal status confirmed with a blood test. If both ovaries have been removed (with or without your uterus), you're in menopause.

- Tamoxifen or an aromatase inhibitor is the endocrine treatment for people in menopause. Aromatase inhibitors include anastrozole (Arimidex), exemestane (Aromasin), and letrozole (Femara).

Preventing pregnancy during treatment

If you become pregnant during radiation therapy or endocrine therapy, it can cause birth defects. Non-hormonal birth control methods, such as intrauterine devices (IUDs) and barrier methods, are preferred in people with a breast cancer diagnosis. Types of barrier methods include condoms, diaphragms, cervical caps, and contraceptive sponges.

Bone-strengthening therapy

Medicines that target the bones may be recommended during treatment for people with invasive breast cancer. Some medicines work by slowing or stopping bone breakdown, while others help increase bone thickness.

Some treatments for breast cancer, like aromatase inhibitors or GnRH agonists, can cause bone loss (osteoporosis), which puts you at an increased risk for fractures. Bone strengthening medicines can reduce risk of osteoporotic fractures and breast cancer recurrence.

Drugs used to prevent bone loss and fractures:

- Oral bisphosphonates
- Zoledronic acid (Zometa)
- Pamidronate (Aredia)
- Denosumab (Prolia)

4 Types of treatment

You may be screened for bone weakness (osteoporosis) using a bone mineral density test. This measures how much calcium and other minerals are in your bones. It's also called a dual-energy x-ray absorptiometry (DEXA) scan. Bone mineral density tests look for osteoporosis and help predict your risk of bone fractures.

You might have blood tests to monitor kidney function, calcium levels, and magnesium levels. A calcium and vitamin D supplement will likely be recommended by your doctor.

Let your dentist know if you're taking any of the medicines listed above. Also, ask your care team how these medicines might affect your teeth and jaw. Osteonecrosis, or bone tissue death of the jaw, is a rare but serious side effect. Tell your care team about any planned trips to the dentist and surgeries or dental procedures that might also affect the jawbone. It's important to take care of your teeth and to see a dentist regularly.

Clinical trials

You may also be able to receive treatment through a clinical trial. A clinical trial is a type of medical research study. After being developed and tested in a lab, potential new ways of treating cancer need to be studied in people.

If found to be safe and effective in a clinical trial, a drug, device, or treatment approach may be approved by the U.S. FDA.

Everyone with cancer should carefully consider all of the treatment options available for their cancer type, including standard treatments and clinical trials. Talk to your doctor about whether a clinical trial may make sense for you.

Phases

Most cancer clinical trials focus on treatment and are done in phases.

- **Phase 1** trials study the safety and side effects of an investigational drug or treatment approach.
- **Phase 2** trials study how well the drug or approach works against a specific type of cancer.
- **Phase 3** trials test the drug or approach against a standard treatment. If the results are good, it may be approved by the FDA.
- **Phase 4** trials study the safety and benefit of an FDA-approved treatment.

Who can enroll?

It depends on the clinical trial's rules, called eligibility criteria. The rules may be about age, cancer type and stage, treatment history, or general health. They ensure that participants are alike in specific ways and that the trial is as safe as possible for the participants.

Informed consent

Clinical trials are managed by a research team. This group of experts will review the study with you in detail, including its purpose and the risks and benefits of joining. All of this information is also provided in an informed consent form. Read the form carefully and ask questions before signing it. Take time to discuss it with people you trust. Keep in mind that you can leave and seek treatment outside of the clinical trial at any time.

Will I get a placebo?

Placebos (inactive versions of real medicines) are almost never used alone in cancer clinical trials. It's common to receive either a placebo with a standard treatment, or a new drug with a standard treatment. You will be informed, verbally and in writing, if a placebo is part of a clinical trial before you enroll.

Are clinical trials free?

There's no fee to enroll in a clinical trial. The study sponsor pays for research-related costs, including the study drug. But you may need to pay for other services, like transportation or childcare, due to extra appointments. During the trial, you'll continue to receive standard cancer care. This care is often covered by insurance.



Finding a clinical trial

In the United States

NCCN Cancer Centers
[NCCN.org/cancercenters](https://www.nccn.org/cancercenters)

The National Cancer Institute (NCI)
[cancer.gov/about-cancer/treatment/clinical-trials/search](https://www.cancer.gov/about-cancer/treatment/clinical-trials/search)

Worldwide

The U.S. National Library of Medicine (NLM)
clinicaltrials.gov

Need help finding a clinical trial?

NCI's Cancer Information Service (CIS)
1.800.4.CANCER (1.800.422.6237)
[cancer.gov/contact](https://www.cancer.gov/contact)

Key points

- Invasive breast cancer might be treated with a combination of surgery, drug (systemic) therapy, and radiation therapy.
- Surgery is often followed by radiation therapy and possible systemic (drug) therapy. In other cases, systemic therapy is given before surgery.
- Radiation therapy uses high-energy radiation from x-rays (photons), protons, and other sources to kill cancer cells.
- Systemic therapy is based on tumor estrogen receptor (ER), progesterone receptor (PR), and HER2 expression.
- Some breast cancers grow because of estrogen. These cancers are estrogen receptor-positive (ER+) and are often treated with endocrine therapy to reduce the risk of cancer returning.
- Endocrine therapy can cause bone loss. Bone-strengthening medicine helps prevent bone loss, broken bones, and bone pain.
- A clinical trial is a type of research that studies a treatment to see how safe it is and how well it works.

Questions to ask

- What is your experience treating breast cancer?
- How many breast cancer surgeries have you done?
- What treatment will I have before and after surgery?
- How long will treatment take and in what order will it be given?
- What websites about my condition do you recommend? Is there any information I can take home to read?

What's next?

Now that you've read about the different types of treatment and what to expect, the next chapter talks about some general side effects of treatment and what might be done to manage those effects.

5

Supportive care

- 44 What is supportive care?
- 44 Side effects
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- 47 Survivorship
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5 Supportive care

Supportive care helps manage the symptoms of invasive breast cancer and the side effects of treatment. This chapter discusses supportive care for possible treatment side effects.

What is supportive care?

Supportive care is an important part of cancer care. The goal is to improve your quality of life during and after cancer treatment. Supportive care is for everyone with cancer and their families, not just for those at the end of life.

Supportive care includes a wide range of services. Supportive care prevents or manages the symptoms of cancer and the side effects of cancer treatment, like pain and cancer-related fatigue. It also addresses the mental, social, emotional, and spiritual concerns faced by people with cancer.

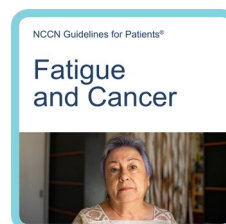
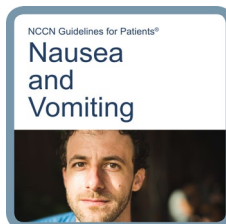
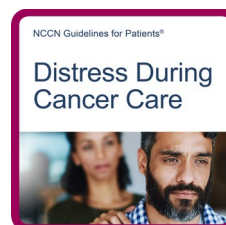
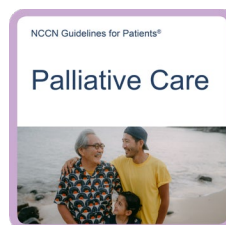
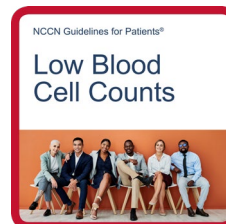
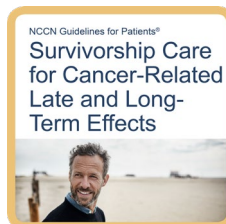
Supportive care provides help with additional needs, such as:

- Making treatment decisions
- Coordinating your care
- Paying for care
- Planning for advanced care and end of life

Read more about the types of support you may receive in *NCCN Guidelines for Patients: Palliative Care*, available at [NCCN.org/patientguidelines](https://www.nccn.org/patientguidelines) and on the [NCCN Patient Guides for Cancer](#) app.

Supportive care resources

More information on supportive care is available at [NCCN.org/patientguidelines](https://www.nccn.org/patientguidelines) and on the [NCCN Patient Guides for Cancer](#) app.



Side effects

All cancer treatments can cause unwanted health issues called side effects. Side effects depend on many factors. These factors include the drug type and dose, length of treatment, and the person. Some side effects may just be unpleasant. Others may be harmful to one's health. Treatment can cause several side effects. Some are very serious. Tell your care team about any new or worsening symptoms.

Some common side effects are described next.

Tell your care team about all of your side effects, including new or worsening symptoms.

Blood clots

Cancer treatment can cause blood clots to form. This can block blood flow and oxygen delivery to parts of the body. Blood clots can break loose and travel to other parts of the body, causing breathing problems, stroke, or other health issues.

Bone health

Breast cancer may spread to your bones. Some breast cancer treatments may also weaken your bones. Both can put your bones at increased risk of injury and disease. Such problems include fractures, bone pain, and squeezing (compression) of the spinal cord. High levels of calcium in the blood, called hypercalcemia, may also occur.

Medicine may be given to help relieve bone pain and reduce the risk of other bone problems. Some medicines work by slowing or stopping bone breakdown, while others help increase bone thickness. It's recommended that you take calcium and vitamin D with these bone health medicines. Talk to your care team first.

Diarrhea or constipation

Diarrhea is frequent and watery bowel movements. Your care team will tell you how to manage diarrhea. When it occurs, it's important to drink lots of fluids.

Constipation means having less frequent and more difficult bowel movements. Constipation is common, especially if you're taking certain pain medicines, including narcotic pain medication and some anti-nausea medications. Drinking fluids, staying active, and taking medicines for constipation are often recommended.

Emotional distress

Depression, anxiety, and sleeping issues are common during a cancer diagnosis. Talk to your care team and those with whom you feel most comfortable about how you're feeling. There are services, people, and medicine that may be recommended to help relieve your distress.

Fatigue

Fatigue is a state of physical or mental tiredness that can feel like a lack of energy, motivation, or stamina. Fatigue may be caused by cancer, or it may be a side effect of treatment. Let your care team know how you're feeling and if fatigue is getting in the way of doing the things you enjoy. Eating a balanced diet, exercise, yoga, acupuncture, and massage therapy can help. You might be referred to a nutritionist or dietitian to help with fatigue. It's important to try to stay active.

Hair loss

Chemotherapy may cause hair loss (alopecia) all over your body—not just on your scalp. Some chemotherapy drugs are more likely than others to cause hair loss. Dosage might also affect the amount of hair loss. Most of the time, hair loss from chemotherapy is temporary. Hair often regrows 3 to 6 months after treatment ends. Your hair may be a different shade or texture at first. Scalp cooling (or scalp hypothermia) might help lessen hair loss in people receiving certain types of chemotherapy.

Infections

Infections are more common and more severe in people with a weakened immune system. Drug treatment for breast cancer can lower the body's natural defense against infections. If not treated early, infections can be fatal.

Neutropenia, a low number of white blood cells that often occurs during treatment, can lead to frequent or severe infections. When someone with neutropenia develops a fever, it's called febrile neutropenia (FN). A fever is a temperature of over 100.4° F. With FN, your risk of infection may be higher than normal. This is because a low number of white blood cells leads to a reduced ability to fight infections. Sometimes the infection can be from bacteria entering the bloodstream, which is very dangerous. FN is a side effect of some types of systemic therapy. Ask your care team how to prevent FN, what to look for, and what to do in an emergency.



It's normal to feel anxious or depressed, and there are things/ medicines that can help. Make sure the people who support you also have access to this help."

Loss of appetite

The side effects from cancer or its treatment and the stress of having cancer might cause you to feel not hungry or sick to your stomach (nauseated). You might have a sore mouth or difficulty swallowing.

Healthy eating is important during treatment. It includes eating a balanced diet, eating the right amount of food, and drinking enough fluids. A registered dietitian who's an expert in nutrition and food can help.

Low blood cell counts

Some cancer treatments can cause low blood cell counts.

- **Anemia** is a condition where your body doesn't have enough healthy red blood cells, resulting in less oxygen being carried to your organs. You might tire easily if you're anemic.
- **Neutropenia** is a decrease in neutrophils, a type of white blood cell. This puts you at risk of infection.
- **Thrombocytopenia** is a condition where there aren't enough platelets found in the blood. This puts you at risk of bleeding.

Lymphedema

Lymphedema is a condition in which lymph fluid builds up in tissues and causes swelling. It may be caused when part of the lymph system is damaged or blocked, such as during surgery to remove lymph nodes, or by radiation therapy. Cancers that block lymph vessels can also cause lymphedema. Swelling usually develops slowly over time. It may develop during treatment, or it may start years after treatment. If you have lymphedema, you may be referred to an expert in lymphedema management. The swelling may be reduced by exercise, massage, compression devices, and other means.

Nausea and vomiting

Nausea and vomiting are common side effects of treatment. You may be given medicine to prevent nausea and vomiting.

Neuropathy and neurotoxicity

Some treatments can damage the nervous system (neurotoxicity), causing neuropathy and problems with concentration, memory, and thinking. Neuropathy is a nerve problem that causes pain, numbness, tingling, swelling, or muscle weakness in different parts of the body. It usually begins in the hands or feet and gets worse with additional cycles of treatment. Most of the time, neuropathy improves gradually and may eventually go away after treatment.

Pain

Tell your care team about any pain or discomfort. You might meet with a palliative care specialist or with a pain specialist to manage pain.

Late effects

Late effects are side effects that occur months or years after a disease is diagnosed or after treatment has ended. Late effects may be caused by cancer or cancer treatment. They may include physical, mental, and social health concerns, as well as second cancers. The sooner late effects are treated, the better. Ask your care team about what late effects could occur. This will help you know what to look for.

Survivorship

A person is a cancer survivor from the time of diagnosis until the end of life. After treatment, your health will be monitored for side effects and the return of cancer. This is part of your survivorship care plan. It's important to keep any follow-up care and imaging test appointments. Seek good routine medical care, including regular doctor visits for preventive care and cancer screening.

A personalized survivorship care plan will contain a summary of possible long-term effects of treatment called late effects and a list of follow-up tests. Find out how your primary care provider will coordinate with specialists for your follow-up care.

Key points

- Supportive care is health care that relieves symptoms caused by treatment and improves quality of life. Supportive care is always given.
- All cancer treatments can cause unwanted health issues called side effects. Side effects depend on many factors. These factors include the drug type and dose, length of treatment, and the person.
- Some side effects are very rare. Ask your care team what to expect.
- Tell your care team about any new or worsening symptoms.
- A person is a cancer survivor from the time of diagnosis until the end of life. After treatment, your health will be monitored for side effects of treatment and the return of cancer.

Questions to ask

- Who will coordinate my care?
- Who should I call when I have questions or notice changes in my condition?
- How long should I wait if I notice changes in my condition?
- What should I do on weekends and other non-office hours?
- Will my care team be able to communicate with the emergency department or urgent care team?

What's next?

The next chapter provides more detailed information on your specific treatment options, which may include a combination of systemic therapy, surgery, and radiation therapy.

“Recovery is the goal. Life will be forever altered because of your cancer experience. There will come a day that your cancer isn’t the first thing that you think of in the morning and the day you realize that happened will be powerful.”



6

Your treatment options

- 50 Surgery first
- 50 Systemic therapy before surgery
- 54 Systemic therapy after surgery
- 55 What's next?
- 58 Follow-up care
- 60 Key points
- 60 Questions to ask

This chapter provides specific treatment options based on the tumor hormone receptor (HR) and HER2 status. It also discusses who might benefit from treatment before surgery. There are many possible treatment combinations. Together, you and your care team will choose a treatment plan that's best for your situation.

Surgery first

Surgery involves removing the tumor from the breast and assessing the lymph nodes for evidence of cancer. Depending on your breast cancer type and clinical stage, systemic therapy may be recommended before surgery.

There are 2 breast surgery options:

- Lumpectomy
- Mastectomy

Surgery might include axillary lymph node staging with sentinel lymph node biopsy, axillary lymph node dissection, or both. After surgery, a pathologist will examine the removed tissue and any lymph nodes to determine the pathologic stage. This information will help plan next steps for treatment. Treatment after surgery might include radiation therapy, systemic therapy, or both.

Lumpectomy first

A lumpectomy, also called a partial mastectomy or breast-conserving surgery, is surgery to remove a tumor in the breast. Treatment after a lumpectomy is based on the type of cancer (histology), the size of the tumor, if cancer is found in the axillary lymph nodes, your age, and if you're in menopause. Many factors play a role in treatment decisions. Most people have radiation therapy (RT) to the breast and sometimes lymph nodes after a lumpectomy. A boost is extra radiation to the tumor area. Systemic (drug) therapy might be given before RT.

Mastectomy first

A total mastectomy is surgery that removes the whole breast. A nipple-sparing or skin-sparing mastectomy may be possible. Treatment after a mastectomy is based on if cancer was found in the axillary lymph nodes, the number of lymph nodes that tested positive for cancer, and the size of the removed tumor. Radiation therapy to the chest wall and lymph nodes, systemic therapy, or both are possible following a mastectomy.

Systemic therapy before surgery

Some cancers benefit from treatment before surgery. These cancers include large tumors, aggressive tumors, cancer in the lymph nodes called nodal or node-positive (N+) disease, or cancer that involves the breast skin or chest wall. Treatment before surgery is called preoperative or neoadjuvant therapy.

6 Your treatment options

Testing

Not everyone benefits from preoperative therapy. If preoperative systemic therapy is an option for you, then you'll have blood and imaging tests before starting treatment. Testing will include an axillary lymph node exam. An ultrasound and biopsy of lymph nodes suspected of cancer are possible.

You will have the following before starting preoperative systemic therapy:

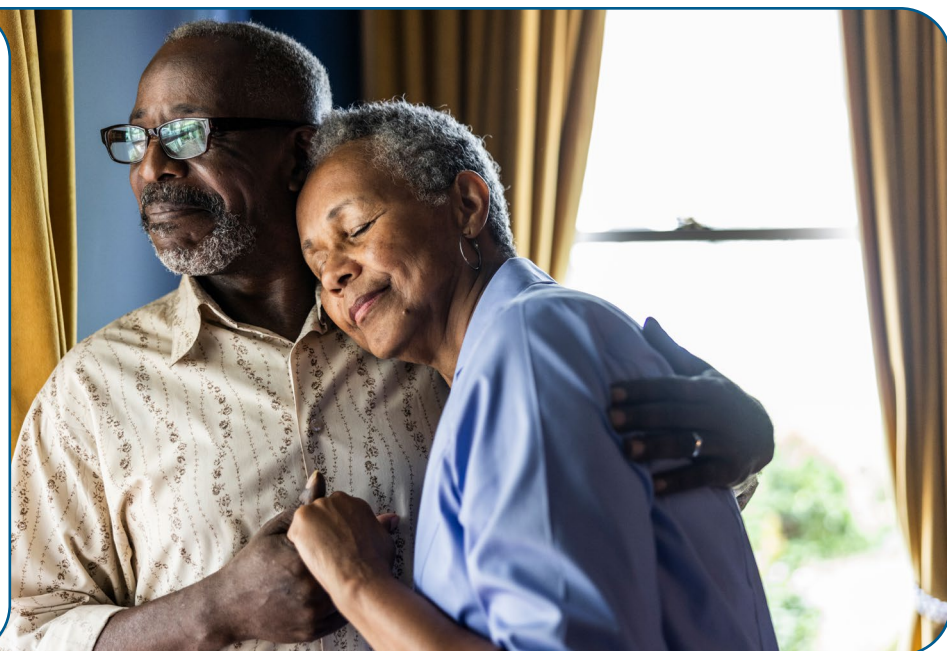
- Core biopsy of breast
- Placement of clips or markers to help the surgeon know where to operate in case the tumor goes away with preoperative therapy. Clips are also placed at the time of surgery for radiation planning.
- Axillary lymph node ultrasound or MRI (if not done before)
- Biopsy of suspicious lymph nodes with clip placement (if not done before)

Treatment before surgery

Systemic (drug) therapy before surgery is based on the tumor hormone receptor (HR) and HER2 status. Preoperative systemic therapy has benefits. The goal is to shrink the tumor or the amount of cancer before surgery. How the tumor responds to drug therapy may affect treatments recommended after surgery.

For preoperative systemic therapy options, see **Guide 4** and **Guide 5**.

"Take things one day or even one step at a time. It might get harder before it gets better, but it will get better."



Guide 4**HER2-targeted therapy options: HER2+ breast cancer**

Preferred therapies	• Docetaxel and Carboplatin plus Trastuzumab plus Pertuzumab (TCHP) • Docetaxel and Carboplatin plus Trastuzumab (adjuvant only) If no disease remains after preoperative therapy or no preoperative therapy: • Complete up to 1 year of HER2-targeted therapy with Trastuzumab. Pertuzumab might be added If disease remains after preoperative therapy: • Ado-trastuzumab emtansine alone. If Ado-trastuzumab emtansine discontinued for toxicity, then Trastuzumab with or without Pertuzumab to complete 1 year of therapy • If node positive at initial staging, then Trastuzumab plus Pertuzumab • Fam-trastuzumab deruxtecan-nxki (T-DXd) for those with high risk of recurrence
Other recommended therapies	• Doxorubicin and Cyclophosphamide (AC) followed by Docetaxel plus Trastuzumab • Doxorubicin and Cyclophosphamide (AC) followed by Docetaxel plus Trastuzumab plus Pertuzumab • Carboplatin and Paclitaxel plus Pertuzumab plus Trastuzumab
Therapies used in certain cases	• Cyclophosphamide and Docetaxel plus Trastuzumab • Doxorubicin and Cyclophosphamide (AC) followed by Paclitaxel plus Trastuzumab • Doxorubicin and Cyclophosphamide (AC) followed by Paclitaxel plus Pertuzumab plus Trastuzumab • Paclitaxel or Docetaxel plus Pertuzumab plus Trastuzumab • Neratinib (adjuvant only) • Ado-trastuzumab emtansine (TDM-1) (adjuvant only) • Paclitaxel plus Trastuzumab (adjuvant only)

Note: Other taxanes (ie, docetaxel, paclitaxel, albumin-bound paclitaxel) might be substituted in some cases.

Guide 5

Systemic therapy options for HER2- breast cancer

**HR+, HER2-
breast cancer****Preferred therapies:**

- Doxorubicin and Cyclophosphamide (AC) followed by Paclitaxel
- Docetaxel and Cyclophosphamide (TC)
- Olaparib, if germline *BRCA1* or *BRCA2* mutations (adjuvant only)

Other recommended therapies:

- Doxorubicin and Cyclophosphamide (AC) followed by Docetaxel
- Epirubicin and Cyclophosphamide (EC)
- Docetaxel, Doxorubicin, and Cyclophosphamide (TAC)

Therapies used in certain cases:

- Doxorubicin and Cyclophosphamide (AC)
- Cyclophosphamide, Methotrexate, and Fluorouracil (CMF)
- Doxorubicin and Cyclophosphamide (AC) followed by Paclitaxel

**HR-, HER2-
(triple-negative)
breast cancer****Preferred therapies:**

- Preoperative Carboplatin and Paclitaxel plus Pembrolizumab, followed by preoperative Cyclophosphamide with Doxorubicin or Epirubicin plus Pembrolizumab, followed by adjuvant Pembrolizumab
- If residual disease after preoperative therapy with taxane-, alkylator-, and anthracycline-based chemotherapy, then Capecitabine

Other recommended therapies:

- Drugs listed above under “HR+, HER2- other recommended therapies”
- Carboplatin and Paclitaxel
- Carboplatin and Docetaxel

Therapies used in certain cases:

- Drugs listed above under “HR+, HER2- other recommended therapies”
- Carboplatin and Docetaxel plus Pembrolizumab (preoperative only)
- Doxorubicin and Cyclophosphamide (AC) followed by Carboplatin and Docetaxel or Paclitaxel
- Capecitabine (maintenance therapy after adjuvant chemotherapy)

Note: Other taxanes (ie, docetaxel, paclitaxel, albumin-bound paclitaxel) might be substituted in some cases.

Surgery

Surgery options depend on how your cancer responded to preoperative therapy. A complete response means there's no evidence of cancer. In a partial response, the tumor in the breast or lymph nodes has shrunk in size. The choice between a lumpectomy or mastectomy is based on the size and location of the tumor, the size of your breast before surgery, and your preference.

If you had preoperative therapy, your tumor will be restaged using tissue removed during surgery. This is called the pathologic (p), or surgical, stage. It might look like this: ypT2N1. The y means you had preoperative therapy. Treatment after surgery might be systemic therapy or radiation or both. It'll likely include endocrine therapy if your tumor is hormone receptor-positive (HR+).

Surgery isn't an option

Surgery isn't always possible. Even though surgery might not be an option, systemic therapy will continue. If the cancer isn't responding to systemic therapy, then radiation may be considered to try to make the cancer resectable (able to be removed with surgery). The goal of treatment is to reduce the amount of cancer. Talk with your care team about your goals of treatment and your treatment preferences. Your wishes are always important.

Systemic therapy after surgery

Adjuvant systemic therapy is drug treatment after surgery. It's given to kill any remaining cancer cells and to help reduce the risk of cancer returning. This treatment is based on cancer stage, which includes lymph node (nodal), hormone receptor (HR), and HER2 status. It's also based on tumor type (histology) and if you're in menopause. Systemic therapies might be used alone or in combination. Ask your care team why one treatment might be preferred over another for your type of cancer.

For people in menopause (natural or induced), bone-strengthening therapy might be given to reduce the risk of distant metastasis.

Common histologies

Information about your tumor's histology can be found in your after-surgery pathology report.

Ductal and lobular carcinoma are the most common histologic types of invasive breast cancer.

Common histology includes the following:

- Ductal/no special type (NST) (NST includes medullary pattern, cancers with neuroendocrine expression, and other rare patterns)
- Lobular
- Mixed
- Micropapillary
- Metaplastic (includes various subtypes)

Favorable histologies

A tumor with a favorable histology isn't high grade, is HER2-, and might respond better to treatment than other tumors. They also might have less risk of returning. People with hormone receptor-positive (HR+) tumors will likely have endocrine therapy. Other systemic therapies or radiation therapy are possible.

Favorable histology includes the following:

- Pure tubular
- Pure mucinous
- Pure cribriform
- Adenoid cystic (conventional), secretory carcinoma, and other salivary carcinomas
- Rare low-grade forms of metaplastic carcinoma
- Other rare forms

21-gene assay

A 21-gene assay (such as Oncotype Dx) is a tumor test used to predict if your cancer might benefit from adjuvant chemotherapy in addition to endocrine therapy. Other tests might be helpful, but a 21-gene assay is the only test proven to predict who would benefit from chemotherapy. Ask your care team for more information if you have questions.

What's next?

The next pages describe systemic therapy based on tumor HR and HER2 status for common histologies. Ductal and lobular are the most common histologies. Typically, the systemic therapy options are the same before and after surgery. Ask your care team for more information.

HR+ and HER2+ breast cancer

Breast cancer that's HR+ and HER2+ is sometimes called triple-positive breast cancer. It's treated with HER2-targeted therapy and endocrine therapy. A CDK4/6 inhibitor may be added.

- Chemotherapy with a HER2-targeted therapy is used to treat HER2+ cancer. HER2-targeted therapy options can be found in **Guide 4**.
- Endocrine therapy is used to treat HR+ breast cancer. It's given after chemotherapy. Endocrine therapy options for HR+ cancer are explained in **Guide 6A** and **Guide 6B**.

HR- and HER2+ breast cancer

HR- and HER2+ treatment focuses on targeting HER2. HER2-targeted therapy usually includes chemotherapy. HER2-targeted therapy options can be found in **Guide 4**.

HR+ and HER2- breast cancer

HER2-targeting therapy isn't used when the tumor is HER2-negative (HER2-). Sometimes, chemotherapy is used. When cancer is found in the lymph nodes, it's called node positive (node+).

- If chemotherapy is given, it's given before endocrine therapy. Chemotherapy and other systemic therapies specific to HER2- breast cancer are listed in **Guide 5**.
- People who are premenopausal might have ovarian suppression or ablation in addition to endocrine therapy. Endocrine therapy options for HR+ cancer can be found in **Guide 6A** and **Guide 6B**.

Triple-negative breast cancer

In triple-negative breast cancer (TNBC), the tumor tested negative for HER2, estrogen receptors, and progesterone receptors. It's written as ER- and/or PR- with HER2-. There are many variations within TNBC. It's a group of diseases that we are learning more about all the time. This cancer is treated with chemotherapy and other systemic therapies found in **Guide 5**.

Endocrine therapy

Endocrine therapy is used to treat hormone receptor-positive (HR+) breast cancer. This is cancer that tests positive for estrogen receptors (ER+), progesterone receptors (PR+), or both (ER+/PR+). Endocrine therapy blocks estrogen and progesterone, which can slow tumor growth or shrink the tumor for a period of time. It might also help prevent the return of cancer in the breasts and elsewhere in the body.

- People with high-risk breast cancer that's HR+ and HER2- might have endocrine therapy with 2 years of adjuvant abemaciclib or 3 years of ribociclib.
- People receiving an aromatase inhibitor (AI) who are at risk of osteoporosis will likely have bone density tests and bone-strengthening therapy.

Endocrine therapy options for HR+ cancer can be found in **Guide 6A** and **Guide 6B**.

Guide 6A

Endocrine therapy for HR+ cancer – premenopausal at diagnosis

Option 1

- Tamoxifen alone or with ovarian suppression or ablation for 5 years



- After 5 years, if in postmenopause, then an aromatase inhibitor for 5 years or consider tamoxifen for another 5 years (for a total of 10 years on tamoxifen)
- After 5 years, if still in premenopause, then consider tamoxifen for another 5 years (for a total of 10 years on tamoxifen) or stop endocrine therapy

Option 2

- Aromatase inhibitor for 5 years with ovarian suppression or ablation, then consider aromatase inhibitor for an additional 3 to 5 years for a total of 7.5 to 10 years

Guide 6B

Endocrine therapy for HR+ cancer – menopausal at diagnosis

Option 1

- Aromatase inhibitor for 5 years, then consider aromatase inhibitor for 3 to 5 more years (for a total of 7.5 to 10 years). Preferred for those with IBC
- Aromatase inhibitor for 2 to 3 years, then tamoxifen to complete 5 years total of endocrine therapy
- Tamoxifen for 2 to 3 years, then an aromatase inhibitor to complete 5 years of endocrine therapy
- Tamoxifen for 2 to 3 years, then up to 5 years of an aromatase inhibitor

Option 2

- Tamoxifen for 4.5 to 6 years, then an aromatase inhibitor for 5 years or consider tamoxifen for another 5 years (for a total of 10 years on tamoxifen)

Option 3

- For those who can't have aromatase inhibitors or who don't want aromatase inhibitors, take tamoxifen for 5 years or consider tamoxifen for up to 10 years

Follow-up care

After treatment, you'll receive follow-up care. During this time, your health will be monitored for side effects of treatment (late effects) and the possible return of cancer (recurrence).

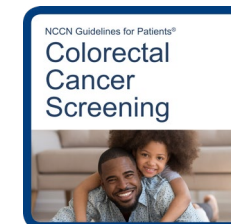
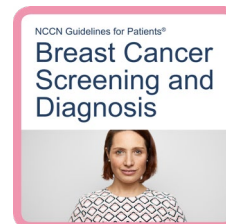
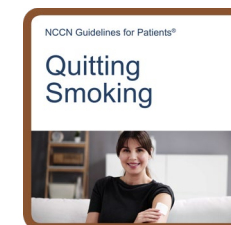
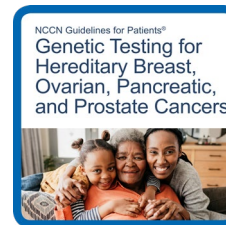
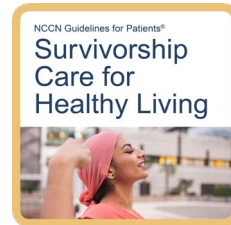
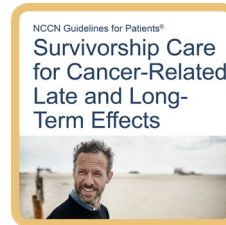
It's important to keep any follow-up visits and imaging test appointments. Seek routine medical care, including regular doctor visits for preventive care and cancer screening. Find out who will coordinate with specialists for your follow-up care.

Tell your care team about any symptoms such as headaches, menstrual spotting between periods or new onset of spotting after menopause (if prior tamoxifen use), shortness of breath that you notice with walking, or bone pain. Side effects can be managed. Continue to take all medicine such as endocrine therapy exactly as prescribed and don't miss or skip doses.

Follow-up care is listed in **Guide 7**.

Follow-up care resources

More information on follow-up care is available at [NCCN.org/patientguidelines](https://www.nccn.org/patientguidelines) and on the [NCCN Patient Guides for Cancer](#) app.



Guide 7 Follow-up care

Medical history and physical exam 1 to 4 times per year as needed for 5 years, then every year

Screening for distress, anxiety, depression, and changes in family history

Genetic testing and referral to genetic counseling, as needed

Monitoring for lymphedema and refer for lymphedema management, as needed

Mammogram every 12 months (not needed for the side that underwent a mastectomy or on reconstructed breast)

Discuss issues and answer questions related to fertility, birth control, sexual health, and menopause hormone therapy (different from endocrine therapy)

Heart tests, as needed

Discuss information on risk of future health issues (comorbidities)

If signs and symptoms of metastases, then blood and imaging tests

If taking endocrine therapy, continue to take endocrine therapy. Don't miss or skip doses.

Annual gynecology exam (depending on age)

Bone density testing if you're on an aromatase inhibitor or if you have ovarian issues

Continue to see all health care providers and specialists as needed. You'll likely have to coordinate your follow-up and routine medical care appointments.

Maintain an ideal body weight (body mass index under 28), be active, eat a healthy diet, limit alcohol, and quit smoking/vaping nicotine

Key points

- There are many possible treatment combinations for invasive breast cancer. Options are based on your type of invasive breast cancer, the clinical (before surgery) cancer stage, and the tumor hormone receptor and HER2 status.
- Treatment for invasive breast cancer may start with surgery. Treatment after surgery might include systemic therapy, radiation therapy, or both. Some people benefit from systemic therapy before surgery.
- In hormone receptor-positive (HR+) cancer, estrogen receptors (ER+), progesterone receptors (PR+), or both (ER+/PR+) are found. Endocrine therapy is given for HR+ cancers to reduce the risk of recurrence.
- HER2-positive (HER2+) cancers are treated with a combination of chemotherapy and HER2-targeted therapy.
- If chemotherapy is given, it's given before radiation therapy and endocrine therapy.
- In triple-negative breast cancer (TNBC), no receptors for estrogen, progesterone, or HER2 are found. It's almost always treated with chemotherapy.
- It's important to keep follow-up visits and imaging test appointments. Seek good routine medical care, including preventive care and cancer screenings. Continue to take all medicines as prescribed.

Questions to ask

- What treatments do you recommend and why?
- Does the order of treatments matter?
- Which option is proven to work best for my type of cancer, age, overall health, and other factors?
- How long will I be on systemic (drug) therapy or endocrine therapy?
- How much time do I have to decide about treatment? Are there any decisions that must be made today?

What's next?

The next chapter discusses how your breast might look after a lumpectomy or mastectomy. You might consider speaking with a plastic surgeon before surgery.

7

The breast after surgery

- 62 After a lumpectomy or partial mastectomy
- 62 Flat closure after a mastectomy
- 62 Breast reconstruction after a mastectomy
- 64 What to consider
- 65 Key points
- 65 Questions to ask

How your breasts look after surgery depends on the type of surgery; the amount of tissue removed; and other factors, such as your body type, age, and size and shape of the area before surgery. You might consider speaking with a plastic surgeon before surgery. This chapter offers more information on flat closure and breast reconstruction.

The recovery time for each procedure differs. This can affect your ability to return to work or participate in activities. You might consider speaking with a plastic surgeon before surgery to discuss your options and what to expect.

After a lumpectomy or partial mastectomy

With a lumpectomy, most people have a scar with some volume loss. However, if you need a large lumpectomy, your breast may be able to be re-shaped at the time of surgery. This is called volume displacement, oncoplasty, or balancing procedure. The surgeon will shift the remaining breast tissue to fill the space left by the removed area.

If you need a larger lumpectomy, sometimes a reconstructive surgeon can replace that tissue with fatty tissue from the back or side of the chest or perform a breast reduction and lift surgery to make the breasts look similar.

Flat closure after a mastectomy

In a total mastectomy with an aesthetic flat closure, the entire breast, nipple, areola, and surrounding extra skin over the breast are removed. The remaining skin is tightened and sewn together. No breast mound is created, and the contour of the chest is smooth. Excess skin should not remain. Ask to look at pictures from flat closures so you know what to expect.

Breast reconstruction after a mastectomy

Breast reconstruction is surgery to rebuild the shape and recreate the look of the breast after a mastectomy. In many cases, breast reconstruction involves a staged approach. This means it requires more than 1 procedure.

You may have a choice as to when breast reconstruction is done.

- **Immediate reconstruction** is finished within hours after removing the breast.
- **Delayed reconstruction** can occur months or years after the cancer surgery.

Reconstruction can also be done in stages, with part of the reconstruction done at the time of the original cancer surgery and finished with another surgery later. A plastic surgeon performs breast reconstruction.

Breasts can be reconstructed with implants and flaps. All methods are generally safe, but as with any surgery, there are risks. Ask your treatment team for a complete list of side effects.

Implants

Breast implants are small bags filled with salt water, silicone gel, or both. They are placed under the breast skin or muscle to mimic a breast shape following a mastectomy. A balloon-like device, called an expander, may be used first to stretch the tissue. It's placed under your skin or muscle and enlarged every few weeks for 2 to 3 months. When your skin is stretched to the proper size, you'll have surgery to place the final implant.

Implants have a small risk of leaking or causing other issues. You may feel pain from the implant or expander. Scar tissue can also arise around the implant, called capsule contracture.

Flaps

Breasts can be remade using skin from other parts of your body, known as flaps. These flaps are taken from your abdomen, buttocks, or thigh, or from under the shoulder blade. Some flaps are completely removed and then sewn in place. Other flaps stay attached to your body but are slid over and sewn into place.

There are several risks associated with flaps, including death of fat in the flap, which can cause lumps. A hernia may result from muscle weakness. Problems are more likely to occur among people who have diabetes or who smoke.

Implants and flaps

Some breasts are reconstructed with both implants and flaps. This method may give the reconstructed breast more volume to match the other breast. For any reconstruction, you may need surgery on your other breast so both breasts match.

Nipple replacement

Like your breast, a nipple can be remade. A plastic surgeon can use surrounding skin to build a new nipple, which can be darkened with a tattoo to look more like a nipple. Or a 3D tattoo can be done to look like a nipple without having to take tissue from another part of the body. It's important to know that while you can remake something to look like a nipple, it won't have the sensation of your original nipple.

"I was so fortunate to find an expert health care team that I could talk to openly and honestly during and after my treatment. This shared decision-making made me feel like I had a say about my care."



What to consider

Below are some factors to think about when deciding whether to have flat closure or reconstruction after mastectomy.

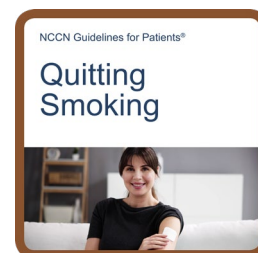
- **Your desire** – You may have a strong feeling toward flat closure or one form of reconstruction after being given the options. Breast reconstruction should be a shared decision between you and your care team. Make your wishes known.
- **Health issues** – Health issues, such as diabetes or a blood disorder, might affect or delay healing or make longer procedures unsafe.
- **Tobacco use** – Smoking delays wound healing and can cause mastectomy flap death, nipple-areola complex death in a nipple-sparing mastectomy, infection, and failure of implant-based reconstruction. In flap reconstruction, smoking increases the risk of complications. You're encouraged to stop smoking prior to breast reconstruction surgery.
- **Breast size and shape** – There are limits to the available sizes of breast implants. Very large breasts or breasts that lack tone or droop (called ptosis) might be difficult to match. Breast reduction surgery might be an option.
- **Body mass index (BMI)** – People with a higher BMI have an increased risk of infections and complications with breast reconstruction.

If you smoke or vape, seek help to quit

Smoking or vaping nicotine greatly increases your chances of having side effects during and after surgery. Smoking and vaping can limit how well cancer treatment works and prevent wound healing. They also increase your chances of developing other cancers. Cannabis use might also affect the amount of anesthesia used during surgery.

Nicotine is the chemical in tobacco that makes you want to keep smoking and vaping. Nicotine withdrawal is challenging for most people who smoke or vape. The stress of having cancer may make it even harder to quit. If you smoke or vape, ask your care team about counseling and medicines to help you quit.

More information can be found in *NCCN Guidelines for Patients: Quitting Smoking* at [NCCN.org/patientguidelines](https://www.nccn.org/patientguidelines) and on the [NCCN Patient Guides for Cancer](#) app.



For online support, try these websites:

- [SmokeFree.gov](https://www.smokefree.gov)
- [CDC.gov/tobacco](https://www.cdc.gov/tobacco)

Key points

- With a lumpectomy, most people have a scar with some volume loss.
- After a large lumpectomy, the breast may be able to be re-shaped at the time of surgery. The surgeon will shift the remaining breast tissue to fill the space left by the removed area.
- Flat closure is done after a mastectomy. The skin is tightened and sewn together without the addition of a breast implant.
- Breast reconstruction is surgery to rebuild the shape and recreate the look of the breast.
- Breasts that are fully removed in a mastectomy can be remade with breast implants, flaps, or both.
- Removed nipples can be remade with body tissue and/or tattooing.

Questions to ask

- What will my breast look like after surgery?
- How many breast surgeries or breast reconstructive surgeries have you done? What complications are possible?
- How much pain will I be in, for how long will I be in pain, and what will be done to manage my pain?
- How long does the breast reconstruction process take and what should I expect?
- What options are available if I don't like the look of my breast after surgery?

What's next?

The next chapter discusses treatment options for an invasive breast cancer that has returned.

8

Recurrence

- 67 Overview
- 67 Tests
- 67 Treatment
- 69 Key points
- 69 Questions to ask

When cancer returns, it's called a recurrence. Treatment is based on the types of treatment you had before. Together, you and your care team will choose a treatment plan that's best for you.

Overview

Breast cancer can return in the following areas:

- The breast or chest wall of the breast that had cancer before. This is called **local recurrence**.
- Axillary lymph nodes or lymph nodes in or near the breast. This is called **regional recurrence**.
- Other distant parts of the body. This is called **metastatic breast cancer**.

You can also have **a new breast cancer** that isn't a recurrence of an earlier cancer.

This chapter presents treatment options for local and regional recurrence.

Tests

You will have tests to learn more about your cancer. Many tests you had when you were first diagnosed will be repeated. This is called re-staging. Tests for recurrence can be found in **Guide 8**.

Treatment

Treatment is based on where the cancer has returned and what type of treatment you had before. You could have surgery followed by radiation therapy (RT) and systemic (drug) therapy. Systemic and endocrine therapy options will be based on tumor hormone receptor (HR) status, HER2 status, and treatments given during your initial cancer treatment. Supportive care will be given. Supportive care aims to relieve side effects of treatment and to improve quality of life.

Guide 8

Possible tests: Recurrence

Medical history and physical exam

Blood tests, such as complete blood count and comprehensive metabolic panel (including liver function tests and alkaline phosphatase)

Chest CT with or without contrast

CT with contrast of abdomen and maybe pelvis (MRI with contrast might be done instead)

Other imaging as needed

Biopsy of tumor or metastasis and test for biomarkers, including estrogen receptor (ER), progesterone receptor (PR), and HER2 status

Genetic counseling if at risk for hereditary breast cancer

Distress screening

Local recurrence

Treatment for cancer that has returned to the same breast is based on if your first treatment was breast-conserving surgery (lumpectomy) or a mastectomy. More surgery might be an option. If you had radiation therapy before, then it may or may not be possible to have radiation again in the same area, which may limit your surgical options. Systemic therapy is possible.

Regional recurrence

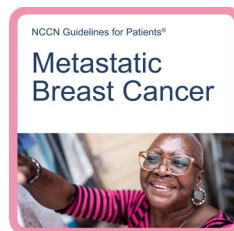
If the recurrence is in or near the armpit (axilla), then surgery to remove the tumor might be an option. You may have systemic therapy before surgery to help reduce the amount of cancer or the size of the tumor. Treatment after surgery might include radiation therapy to the lymph nodes. If you had radiation therapy before, then it may not be possible to have it again in the same area. Systemic therapy after surgery is possible.

Both local and regional

Cancer that's both local and regional might be referred to as a locoregional recurrence. Treatment for a locoregional recurrence is surgery and radiation therapy followed by systemic therapy.

Unresectable

An unresectable tumor can't be removed with surgery. It's treated with systemic therapy. For treatment of unresectable recurrent disease, see *NCCN Guidelines for Patients: Metastatic Breast Cancer*, available at [NCCN.org/patientguidelines](https://www.nccn.org/patientguidelines) and on the [NCCN Patient Guides for Cancer](#) app.



Key points

- When cancer returns, it's called a recurrence.
- Cancer that returns to the breast that had cancer before is called a local recurrence.
- Cancer that returns to axillary lymph nodes or lymph nodes in or near the breast is called a regional recurrence.
- Cancer that returns to distant parts of the body is called metastatic breast cancer.
- Treatment is based on where the cancer has returned and what type of treatment you had before.
- Surgery followed by radiation therapy and systemic therapy are possible. Systemic and endocrine therapy options are based on hormone receptor (HR) and HER2 status, and any mutations found.
- An unresectable tumor can't be removed with surgery. Unresectable recurrent disease is treated with systemic therapy.

Questions to ask

- Where is the cancer located and what does this mean for my treatment options?
- Which course of treatment do you recommend and why?
- Is surgery an option? What treatment might I have before and after surgery?
- What role do previous treatments, my age, menopause status, and overall health play in treatment options?
- Am I a candidate for a clinical trial?

What's next?

The next chapter provides information about resources and where you can get support.

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Other resources

71 What else to know

71 What else to do

71 Where to get help

72 Questions to ask

Want to learn more? Here's how you can get additional help.

What else to know

This guide helps you know your options so you can make informed decisions and improve your cancer care. But it's not the only resource that you have.

Ask for as much information and help as you need. Many people are interested in learning more about:

- Finding an oncologist or surgeon who is an expert in breast cancer
- Making treatment decisions
- The details of treatment and possible side effects
- Getting financial help
- Coping with cancer treatment and other health challenges

What else to do

Your health care center can help you with next steps. It often has on-site resources to help meet your needs and find answers to your questions. Health care centers can also inform you of resources in your community.

In addition to help from your providers, the resources listed in the next section provide support for many people like yourself.

Where to get help

Look through the list below and visit the provided websites to learn more about these organizations.

Bone Marrow & Cancer Foundation
bonemarrow.org

Breast Cancer Alliance
breastcanceralliance.org

Breastcancer.org
breastcancer.org

Brem Foundation to Defeat Breast Cancer
bremfoundation.org

CanCare, Inc.
cancare.org

CancerCare
cancercares.org

Cancer Hope Network
cancerhopenetwork.org

Cancer Survivor Care
cancersurvivorcare.org

DiepC Foundation
diepcfoundation.org

FORCE: Facing Our Risk of Cancer Empowered
facingourrisk.org

GPAC Global Patient Advocacy Coalition
GPACunited.org

HIS Breast Cancer Awareness
hisbreastcancer.org

Imerman Angels
imermanangels.org

Inflammatory Breast Cancer Research Foundation
ibcresearch.org

Lobular Breast Cancer Alliance
lobularbreastcancer.org

My Faulty Gene
myfaultygene.org

PAN Foundation
panfoundation.org

Sharsheret
sharsheret.org

Stupid Cancer
stupidcancer.org

Triage Cancer
triagecancer.org

Unite for HER
uniteforher.org

Young Survival Coalition (YSC)
youngsurvival.org

Questions to ask

- Who can I talk to about help with housing, food, and other basic needs?
- What help is available for transportation, childcare, and home care?
- What other services are available to me and my caregivers?
- How can I connect with others and build a support system?
- Who can I talk to if I don't feel safe at home, at work, or in my neighborhood?

"If you notice something strange or different on your body, get it checked out. Early detection of any cancer generally means a more successful outcome. Stay positive, ask lots of questions, and above all, ask for help when you need it."





Words to know

adjuvant therapy

Treatment to lower the chances of the cancer returning.

antibody drug conjugate (ADC)

A substance made up of a protein linked to a drug that attaches and enters certain types of cancer cells.

anti-estrogen

A drug that stops estrogen from attaching to cells.

areola

A darker, round area of skin on the breast around the nipple.

aromatase inhibitor (AI)

A drug that lowers estrogen levels.

axillary lymph node (ALN)

A small disease-fighting structure near the armpit (axilla).

axillary lymph node dissection (ALND)

An operation that removes lymph nodes near the armpit.

bilateral oophorectomy

An operation that removes both ovaries.

biopsy

A procedure that removes fluid or tissue samples to be tested for a disease.

bone mineral density

A test that measures the strength of bones.

bone scan

A test that makes pictures of bones to look for health problems.

breast implant

A small bag filled with salt water, gel, or both used to remake breasts.

breast reconstruction

An operation that creates new breasts.

cancer stage

A rating of the outlook of a cancer based on its growth and spread.

chest wall

The layer of muscle, bone, and fat that protects the vital organs.

clinical breast exam

Touching of a breast by a health expert to feel for diseases.

clinical stage (c)

A rating of the extent of cancer before treatment is started.

clinical trial

A type of research that assesses health tests or treatments.

contrast

A substance put into your body to make clearer pictures during imaging tests.

core needle biopsy

A procedure that removes tissue samples with a hollow needle.

diagnostic mammogram

Pictures made from x-rays focused on specific areas inside of the breasts.

duct

A tube-shaped structure through which milk travels to the nipple.

ductal carcinoma

A cancer derived from cells that line small, tube-shaped vessels.

endocrine therapy

A cancer treatment that stops the making or action of estrogen. Also called hormone therapy.

estrogen

A hormone that plays a role in breast development.

estrogen receptor (ER)

A protein inside of cells that binds to estrogen.

estrogen receptor-negative (ER-)

A type of breast cancer that doesn't use estrogen to grow.

estrogen receptor-positive (ER+)

A type of breast cancer that uses estrogen to grow.

fertility specialist

An expert who helps people have babies.

fine-needle aspiration (FNA)

A procedure that removes tissue samples with a very thin needle.

flat closure

A procedure done after a mastectomy in which the skin is tightened and sewn together without the addition of a breast implant.

gene

Coded instructions in cells for making new cells and controlling how they behave.

genetic counseling

Expert guidance on the chance for a disease passed down in families.

hereditary breast cancer

Breast cancer likely caused by abnormal genes passed down from biological parent to child.

histology

The structure of cells, tissue, and organs as viewed under a microscope.

hormone

A chemical that triggers a response from cells or organs.

hormone receptor-negative cancer (HR-)

Cancer cells that don't use hormones to grow.

hormone receptor-positive cancer (HR+)

Cancer cells that use hormones to grow.

human epidermal growth factor receptor 2 (HER2)

A protein on the surface of a cell that sends signals for the cell to grow.

immunohistochemistry (IHC)

A lab test of cancer cells to find specific cell traits involved in abnormal cell growth.

inflammatory breast cancer (IBC)

A type of breast cancer in which the breast looks red and swollen and feels warm to the touch.

infraclavicular

The area right below the collarbone.

in situ hybridization (ISH)

A lab test that counts the number of copies of a gene.

internal mammary

The area along the breastbone.

invasive breast cancer

The growth of breast cancer into the breast's supporting tissue. Also called early-stage breast cancer.

lobule

A gland in the breast that makes breast milk.

luteinizing hormone-releasing hormone (LHRH)

A hormone in the brain that helps control the making of estrogen by the ovaries.

lymph

A clear fluid containing white blood cells.

lymphedema

Swelling caused by a buildup of fluid called lymph.

lymph node

A small, bean-shaped, disease-fighting structure.

magnetic resonance imaging (MRI)

A test that uses radio waves and powerful magnets to take pictures of the inside of the body.

mammogram

A picture of the inside of the breast made using x-rays.

mastectomy

An operation that removes the whole breast.

menopause

12 months after the last menstrual period.

modified radical mastectomy

An operation that removes the whole breast and lymph nodes under the arm (axilla).

mutation

An abnormal change.

neoadjuvant treatment

A treatment given before the main treatment to reduce the cancer. Also called preoperative treatment if given before surgery.

nipple-areola complex (NAC)

The ring of darker breast skin is called the areola. The raised tip within the areola is called the nipple.

pathologic stage (p)

A rating of the extent of cancer given after examining tissue removed during surgery.

pathologist

A doctor who's an expert in testing cells and tissue to find disease.

positron emission tomography (PET)

A test that uses radioactive material to see the shape and function of body parts.

premenopause

The state of having menstrual periods.

progesterone

A hormone involved in sexual development, menstrual periods, and pregnancy.

progesterone receptor (PR)

A protein inside of cells that binds to progesterone.

prognosis

The likely course and outcome of a disease based on tests.

radiation therapy (RT)

A treatment that uses high-energy rays. Also called radiotherapy.

radical mastectomy

An operation that removes the whole breast, lymph nodes under the arm (axilla), and chest wall muscles under the breast.

recurrence

The return of cancer after a cancer-free period.

selective estrogen receptor degrader (SERD)

A drug that blocks and destroys estrogen receptors.

selective estrogen receptor modulator (SERM)

A drug that blocks the effect of estrogen inside of cells.

sentinel lymph node (SLN)

The first lymph node to which cancer cells spread after leaving a tumor.

sentinel lymph node biopsy (SLNB)

An operation to remove the disease-fighting structures (lymph nodes) to which cancer first spreads. Also called sentinel lymph node dissection.

side effect

An unhealthy or unpleasant physical or emotional response to treatment.

supportive care

Health care that includes symptom relief but not cancer treatment. Also called palliative care or best supportive care.

supraclavicular

The area right above the collarbone.

systemic therapy

Drug treatment that works throughout the body.

TNM score

A system used to stage breast cancer. The letters T (tumor), N (node), and M (metastasis) describe different areas of cancer growth.

total mastectomy

An operation that removes the entire breast with a flat closure. Also called simple mastectomy.

triple-negative breast cancer (TNBC)

A breast cancer that doesn't use hormones or the HER2 protein to grow.

ultrasound

A test that uses sound waves to take pictures of the inside of the body.



We want your feedback!

Our goal is to provide helpful and easy-to-understand information on cancer.

Take our survey to let us know what we got right and what we could do better.

[NCCN.org/patients/feedback](https://www.nccn.org/patients/feedback)



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University Hospitals Seidman Cancer Center and
Cleveland Clinic Taussig Cancer Institute
Cleveland, Ohio

City of Hope National Medical Center
Duarte, California

Dana-Farber Cancer Institute
Boston, Massachusetts

Duke Cancer Institute
Durham, North Carolina

Fox Chase Cancer Center
Philadelphia, Pennsylvania

Fred & Pamela Buffett Cancer Center
Omaha, Nebraska

Fred Hutchinson Cancer Center
Seattle, Washington

Huntsman Cancer Institute at the University of Utah
Salt Lake City, Utah

Indiana University Melvin and Bren Simon
Comprehensive Cancer Center
Indianapolis, Indiana

Johns Hopkins Kimmel Cancer Center
Baltimore, Maryland

Mass General Brigham Cancer Institute
Boston, Massachusetts

Mayo Clinic Comprehensive Cancer Center
Phoenix/Scottsdale, Arizona
Jacksonville, Florida
Rochester, Minnesota

Memorial Sloan Kettering Cancer Center
New York, New York

Moffitt Cancer Center
Tampa, Florida

O'Neal Comprehensive Cancer Center at UAB
Birmingham, Alabama

Robert H. Lurie Comprehensive Cancer Center
of Northwestern University
Chicago, Illinois

Roswell Park Comprehensive Cancer Center
Buffalo, New York

Siteman Cancer Center at Barnes-Jewish Hospital
and WashU Medicine
St. Louis, Missouri

St. Jude Children's Research Hospital/
The University of Tennessee Health Science Center
Memphis, Tennessee

Stanford Cancer Institute
Stanford, California

The Ohio State University Comprehensive Cancer Center -
James Cancer Hospital and Solove Research Institute
Columbus, Ohio

The UChicago Medicine Comprehensive Cancer Center
Chicago, Illinois

The University of Texas MD Anderson Cancer Center
Houston, Texas

UC Davis Comprehensive Cancer Center
Sacramento, California

UC San Diego Moores Cancer Center
La Jolla, California

UCLA Jonsson Comprehensive Cancer Center
Los Angeles, California

UCSF Helen Diller Family Comprehensive Cancer Center
San Francisco, California

University of Colorado Cancer Center
Aurora, Colorado

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Ann Arbor, Michigan

University of Wisconsin Carbone Cancer Center
Madison, Wisconsin

UT Southwestern Simmons
Comprehensive Cancer Center
Dallas, Texas

Vanderbilt-Ingram Cancer Center
Nashville, Tennessee

Yale Cancer Center/Smilow Cancer Hospital
New Haven, Connecticut

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